THE UNFINISHED SWAN

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Based on the game 'THE UNFINISHED SWAN' by
Giant Sparrow

2ND POLISH: 4/15/24

PlayStation

P: Carter Swan, Anne-Marie Lee

WHITE

No detail. No shade. Just BLANK SPACE.

Pristine… Steady… Daunting…

At the center, a tiny BLACK DOT begins to--

FADE IN:

Swelling like an inkblot, developing into a **BLACK** and **WHITE**

POLAROID

Striking and high contrast, it depicts a small, deep-south LAKE TOWN. Children skip puddles. Umbrella tops flail. All frozen in time beneath a grueling fall thunderstorm.

Suddenly, the POLAROID vanishes. It's **WHITE** again… Another image fades in, ushering us into--

A SERIES OF POLAROID PICTURES:

- A hand-painted sign reads '**WELCOME TO FINCHWOOD LAKE**'.

- COMMUTERS huddle for cover beneath a bus stop.

- A flock of gulls soars over an eerie grey LIGHTHOUSE.

- A UNHOUSED MAN drinks beside his handcrafted BLACK POTS.

- Cracked walls. Cracked pavement. Cracked rooftops.

- A ROOSTER weathervane tarnished by an unsightly BLACK STAIN.

- A drenched JOGGER sprints along a web of weathered CANALS.

The sleepy town snoozes beneath a blanket of dew and untamed ivy -- the kind of place cloaked in perpetual grey, even on a sunny day. Old and new facades exist side by side in a delightful jumble of Alabama charm and Venetian elegance.

We hold on a…

PHOTO OF THE CANAL BRIDGE

A SMALL BLUR of movement comes into focus, walking towards us in this frozen world.

This is **MONROE** (20). Awkward. Sarcastic. The emotional burden of teenage indecision strung high upon his scrawny shoulders.

And it looks like he just robbed a Party City.

(CONTINUED)

On his head, a PARTY CONE HAT reads “TODAY’S MY BIRTHDAY!” He bites a KAZOO between his teeth and wears a fancy business JACKET. Affixed to his wrist -- a bouquet of BALLOONS.

He grips a FILM CANISTER, strolling past the FROZEN TOWNSFOLK with a jolly grin.

As his body glazes each raindrop, it MELTS into liquid for a moment, and then, **AS IF TIME REVERSES**, it flickers and reforms back in the air.

A zigzagging line of reforming droplets snakes behind him. Shimmering like a thousand iridescent stars.

Monroe descends a staircase to street level, entering the--

PHOTO UNDER THE CANAL BRIDGE

The **UNHOUSED MAN** (Nolan, 40s) gazes at the murky canal water flooding his camp. Handcrafted pots line a tarp beside him.

MONROE
Evenin’, Nolan. How’s the job hunt?
(listens a beat)
Brought you something to help.

Monroe clamps the balloon string under a heavy pot to pin it in place, then cloaks his jacket over Nolan, struggling to string the man’s unmoving arms through the sleeves.

MONROE (CONT’D)
Mr. Wellington won’t be missing it.
Looks better on you anyway.

The jacket PUFFS OUT, attempting to FLOAT AWAY as if an unnatural wind were pulling it. He pats the sleeves down.

MONROE (CONT’D)
Better hold onto that though --
don’t want it resetting…

He turns to see his balloons *slipping free* from the pot. But they drift HORIZONTALLY, not upward. Back to Party City. Carried by that same unnatural wind pulling the jacket.

MONROE (CONT’D)
Oops. Case in point.

Unfazed, he raises a Polaroid CAMERA. Well-loved, he understands every little dial on this dingy contraption.

With the precision of a surgeon, he lines up the perfect shot--

SNAP. A Polaroid sputters out. He smiles proudly at his work.

(CONTINUED)

MONROE (CONT'D)
THANK YOU for remembering! I'm 18.
Or was it 19?… Crap.
(beat, then)
What I do know is I'm old enough
for one of these--

He swipes the OPEN BOTTLE OF BEER from Nolan's grip. But as he raises it to his lips, the LIQUID STAYS IN PLACE, floating mid-air. Annoyed, he sucks at the blob of BOTTLE-SHAPED BEER--

But as he touches it, the liquid splatters, DRENCHING HIM before floating back up like the rain. He ditches the bottle, which refills itself as it settles back in Nolan's grip.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Ugh, I was hoping you wouldn't ask.
Still no word from that Nat Geo
contest, but maybe tomorrow. Ha.
(shows polaroid)
Hey, look! You didn't blink.

Chuckles at his silly joke… then raises his FILM REEL proudly.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Better get going. Busy day planned!
(as he walks off)
Tomorrow. I have a good feeling
about tomorrow… You'll see.

With confidence, he exits the frame, but we--

STAY ON NOLAN as the jacket LOOSENS and UNSTRAPS. It joins the balloons, floating back down the streets along a straight path… as if the wind were reeling it in on a fishing line.

Resetting back to where Monroe first found them.

We follow the balloons zooming up the streets, entering the--

PHOTO OF THE CANALS

More frozen images -- FISHERMEN in dingy boats drifting along quaint canals, KIDS fleeing the rain under stone grey arches.

Monroe jogs along the towpath, high-fiving a jogger, **FRED** (50s), frozen mid-struggle.

MONROE
Thanks, Fred! Lookin' fit. Keep up
the good work!

The incomplete air of this town fully reveals itself: Bridges lead to nowhere, scaffolds prop up balconies, skeletal docks jut from shore, caught between construction and collapse.

But one motif runs throughout it all -- a CONSTRUCTION LOGO.

It's for **KING CONSTRUCTION CO** and its omnipresence feels ingrained into this town's Southern Gothic architecture.

PHOTO OF "KING'S GARDEN", COURTYARD

We follow the canal as it threads past a lush garden -- an intricate HEDGE MAZE inspired by the Palace of Versailles.

At the maze's entrance, a majestic KING STATUE fountain prevails over a courtyard of whimsical animal-shaped TOPIARIES.

Across from the king, a smaller fountain with an EMPTY PEDESTAL for another statue -- never completed.

Monroe does a goofy curtesy as he passes the King statue.

PHOTO OF THE MARINA

Monroe continues along the boardwalk, passing sleepy vessels nestled together like sardines. He stops at a SNACK STAND and selects an ice cream served in a BOAT-SHAPED SOUVENIR CUP.

Off the dock, **ELLIE** (mid-20s, stressed) and **JASON** (mid-20s, relaxed), disembark a flooded SWAN ROWBOAT, frozen amidst an argument. A sopping-wet Ellie shoots Jason a nasty grimace.

Monroe jogs into frame, chewing BUBBLE GUM now.

MONROE
Yo Jason! Ellie! Check it out --
it's like a yoyo for my mouth.

He blows a BUBBLE. POP! Then, like the raindrops, time REVERSES, and the bubble REFORMS. But Monroe's smile fades--

Also in the boat, a tearful **HAZEL** (6) cradles a stuffed FROG.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Happy birthday, Hazel. Next year
will be better. Promise.

Monroe removes his PARTY CONE HAT and fixes it around Hazel.

PHOTO OF THE LIGHTHOUSE

In the distance, a pensive LIGHTHOUSE towers above a storm-battered lake. A CLOCK at its peak forever reads **10:16 AM.**

Monroe aims his lens across the lake, near the edge of town -- a monstrous CONSTRUCTION SITE invades his viewfinder.

Unnerved, he lowers his camera. No photos of that…

PHOTO OF COASTAL OVERLOOK

NATALIE (16, glasses) and **MAXINE** (16, trendy) snap a SELFIE, radiating with the flush cheeks of insecure, in-love high schoolers as they cuddled beneath an umbrella.

A regal TELESCOPE beside them wears decades of rust.

Monroe crashes it with an obnoxious pose, snapping a Polaroid. He notices how the girls' pinkies slightly interweave--

MONROE
(whispers to Natalie)
Just tell her how you feel already.

--And touches the side of HIS pinky to theirs.

PHOTO OF THE BUS STOP

At the intersection of CROWN STREET and MAJESTY AVE, Monroe reaches a bus stop crowded with ASSORTMENT OF FOLKS,

Monroe sits and takes a breather, smiling at his friends. each with a vibrant story, huddle beneath the awning.

MONROE
Hey everyone! Now don't get up or anything, but today is a very special day… I think. Today I'm turning 21 and want everyone to…

Behind him, Nolan's JACKET drifts by. The BALLOONS follow--

PULL OUT TO REVEAL *these scenes aren't just inside photos*.

This frozen town -- THIS IS MONROE'S WORLD.

EXT. WELLINGTON MANSION, FRONT DOOR - LATER

The ostentatious villa rises above the magnolia trees like a marble crown. Wide columns and sweeping porches. A relic of antebellum design, exuding wealth and pride.

Monroe strolls up the gravel drive… Nolan's JACKET hovers outside the double doors, attempting to enter.

He sighs at the JACKET, opens the doors--

INT. WELLINGTON MANSION, FOYER/KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Plush sofas. A crystal chandelier. Portraits of ancestors.

As the door opens, the JACKET propels ahead of Monroe, landing on the shoulders of **MR. WELLINGTON** (50s, 'time is money'), as it resets to its original 'frozen world' place.

In the opulent kitchen, **MRS. WELLINGTON** (50s, adorned in pearls) instructs STAFF setting up for a party.

Monroe swaggers in, swiping a deviled egg off a tray.

MONROE
Howdy, Mrs. Wellington, is this all for me? Awwww, you shouldn't have.

He lays down two slices of bread, STABBING a slice with a KNIFE to pin it in place. Prancing around the kitchen, he opens every cabinet as he rambles.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I'm 26! I can rent a car! Well… not like it would start in Stillness.

Marshmallow fluff, chocolate sauce, and rainbow sprinkles mush onto his bread like sugary finger paint.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I'm just glad I can still eat. I keep wondering though -- if I froze while needing to pee, like, would I need to pee <u>all the time</u>? Now these are important questions.

The knife hovers -- he turns back, SNATCHING it out of the air, not missing a beat. He scans a row of fancy hors d'oeuvres.

MONROE (CONT'D)
… Almost as important as deciding between beluga or osetra caviar?

Shrug. He plops BOTH on the bread, trapping his messy spread and -- and voilà! Birthday sandwich à la frozen world!

And no need to clean up because the knife is already sparkling, the condiments re-capped and re-shelved.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I gave Nolan the jacket by the way!

He frowns at the jacket, reset upon Wellington's shoulders.

MONROE (CONT'D)
But, um, not sure anything I do here actually matters. I don't know… What do you think?

He pauses. As if really wanting her guidance… *Sigh.*

MONROE (CONT'D)
Right, well. Better be on my way. You know what they say, Mam. Time flies when you're having fun… Haha.

Monroe jams his weird sandwich deep enough into his boat cup filled with never-melting ice cream to keep it stuck.

INT. FINCHWOOD HIGH SCHOOL, HALLWAYS - LATER

Buzzing with back-to-school vibes, Monroe traces a mesmerized route between FROZEN STUDENTS, playfully greeting them.

MONROE
Love the new hair, Riley. Yo--
Joey! Did you have a growth spurt?

He grabs an old HAND-CRANK FILM PROJECTOR from a teacher.

EXT. INDUSTRIAL PLANT - DAY

A symphony of steel snakes across the skyline like a modern-day castle. SILOS rise like turrets. WORKERS patrol like loyal knights, frozen with tools raised or driving machinery.

Monroe navigates a web of chutes, rolling his projector to the top of a silo and thrusting it through the metal hatch--

INT. SILO - CONTINUOUS

--where it CRASHES on the earth below and breaks. No worries as it just rebuilds. Monroe reels over a LADDER floating along the silo's circumference and drops into the cavernous space.

Frozen dust particles sway as Monroe releases his Polaroids:

Natalia, Maxine, Nolan, and Fred scatter the air, FLATTENING AGAINST THE WALL, attempting to reset to their capture point.

A METAL SIGN above the photos reads "**CAPTURING STILLNESS.**"

With pride, he arranges his new photos with previous photos of the town, creating a gallery exhibit.

WIDEN TO REVEAL an ECLECTIC COLLECTION of objects reset along the silo walls -- comic books, a fedora, an electric guitar, action figures, more BOAT CUPS.

Anything a teenage boy might find cool "hangs" in his fortress... among candy wrappers, beer bottles.

He passes a tear-off CALENDAR of upbeat messages, ripping off the date: *'Every day is a new beginning!'* The page reforms.

Then he sinks into a giant BEAN BAG, aiming his projector at a SAIL hung across like a makeshift screen--

CUT TO:

MOMENTS LATER

ON SCREEN: Paused in amidst a memory, **YOUNG MONROE (5)** dons a FAMILIAR PARTY HAT on a quaint SAILBOAT. A bright sunny day. Calm waves rock the hull as he playfully draws a picture.

Monroe cranks the projector handle backward, rewinding it, and then releasing it. TIME RESETS IT SO IT PLAYS FORWARD.

WOMAN'S VOICE (O.S.)
…Happy Birthday dear Monroe… Happy birthday to you!

A FAMILIAR BOAT CUP floats into frame, filled with ice cream. Monroe sings along as his younger self blows out a candle.

SIX BALLOONS tumble around him the deck, linked by a string. Young Monroe jumps up and darts around, popping them one by one as the voice counts on.

WOMAN'S VOICE (O.S.) (CONT'D)
One! Two! Three! Four! Five!

He reaches the LAST ONE, bulging with a surprise. Considers it… Then beelines back to his drawing instead.

WOMAN'S VOICE (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Monroe! You have to pop the last one so you can turn six.

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
That's okay. I like being five.

WOMAN'S VOICE (O.S.)
You don't want to grow up?

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
Can't. I'm too busy.

The stubborn young boy colors in an imaginative SEA MONSTER.

We hear the laughter of **AURORA LARK** (30s), PAINT always caked between her knuckles, we only ever see snippets of her, but imagine a playful, passionate woman behind the voice.

MONROE
(to video)
Hey Mom. Another year gone by.

GRANT (30s) sidles into view from behind the boat's wheel -- or more like Grant's big belly. The lumbering shy giant hides behind a WRAPPED GIFT, but Monroe pays him no attention.

AURORA (O.S.)
Oh no! If you're not growing up--
that means I'm slooowing dooown…

The view tilts to the deck as Aurora pretends to power down like a robot. Little Monroe gleefully joins in her game, rushing over to poke and prod her rigid body.

She TICKLES him back -- he giggles and stumbles backward, accidentally landing on the FINAL BALLOON with a -- POP!

Confetti and glitter POOF UP around him! With wonder, Monroe picks up the handcrafted SEA MONSTER FIGURINE inside, matching his drawing. Grant rubs his calloused hands proudly.

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
Awww, can I be five again?

AURORA (O.S.)
Hm depends. Can I be five again?

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
Noooo cause you're my mommy!!

AURORA (O.S.)
Fine. Let's make a deal then. If you move forward in time, so will I.

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
Okay. Promise?

She unsheathes a **SILVER PAINTBRUSH** and dabs **PINK** PAINT onto Monroe's pinkie, then her own. They wiggle them side-by-side…

AURORA (O.S.)
Pink promise…

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
A pink promise lasts forever, right?

With a timid smile, Grant extends the WRAPPED GIFT.

AURORA (O.S.)
And so will this. This is from Mommy's new friend, Grant.

He tears it open to discover a **POLAROID CAMERA.** Excited, he aims the lens at Aurora and Grant. Directly at us.

SNAP! The reel CRANKS to a halt on Young Monroe's lens.

BACK TO our Monroe, clenching that SAME WRINKLED POLAROID, Aurora's face obscured by her SUPER 8 CAMERA filming him.

MONROE
What's it like in there, Mom?

He jams a lit cigarette into his sandwich like a candle. Blows it out and devours it. Yum. Weird.

Sinking into the beanbag, he yawns. In his pocket, the dim glow of a PHONE SCREEN lights the room a wispy blue, frozen at **10:16 AM.** Frustrated, he tosses it away--

But the phone SWOOPS back over, trying to burrow back into his pocket. Annoyed he flips over. His eyelids droop.

As he dozes off, HIS BODY slowly begins to RISE and FLOAT up, slipping out through the top of the silo.

EXT. TOP OF SILO/ABOVE FINCHWOOD - MOMENTS LATER

Like a freed balloon, Monroe's sleeping body bobs above the town, drifting through the endless ocean of frozen rain.

RESETTING BACK TO **HIS PLACE**, LIKE ALL OBJECTS IN THIS WORLD.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. COMMUNITY CENTER, GALLERY - DREAM SEQUENCE

A banner for "FINCHWOOD ART FAIR" drapes the gallery. The bustle of LOCAL ARTISTS setting up exhibits and booths. Time moves normally in dreams, saturated in sickly vibrant color.

*We find Monroe shoveling through a box of his PHOTOS, dressed in an OVERSIZED SUIT. The familiar exhibit sign reads '**CAPTURING STILLNESS**,' but remains an empty WHITE WALL.*

Monroe holds up a lovely landscape photo, considering.

AURORA (O.S.)
Oh, I like that one.

*He grimaces at **AURORA**, perched on a box, casually painting. Paintbrushes puncture her messy bun, peaking over the canvas that always blocks her face.*

MONROE
No… How can you always just sit there and paint like that?

AURORA (O.S.)
Easy. Like this--

She splatters a streak of PINK paint onto his blank wall.

MONROE
This is SERIOUS, Mom. A rep from Getty is coming… and I can't spend another year at home.

His jealousy sizzles as he eyes all the beautiful exhibits coming to life around him.

He wipes off the paint, accidentally smudging his sleeve.

MONROE (CONT'D)
It's too big. He got me a size too big--

AURORA (O.S.)
Just wear it for the day. Please. It'll make him so happy…

Aurora's phone buzzes. She suddenly becomes cold and robotic.

AURORA (CONT'D)
I need to leave now.

MONROE
What? But my exhibit--

As Monroe looks up -- the colors of the dream begin to hemorrhage and spill, blurring the features of her face.

AURORA
I'm sorry. There's not enough time.

With that, she turns on her heels and leaves.

Monroe grows frantic -- everyone in the room is staring at him, exchanging judgmental whispers and glances.

Anxiety buzzing in his chest, he rushes out after her.

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER/DREAM SEQUENCE

The town centerpiece, the majestic BRIDGE spans across the lake, offering breathtaking views of the horizon.

But Monroe focuses on the boats below, scrambling down a steep embankment to a lakefront dock at the bottom.

EXT. AURORA'S SAILBOAT, LAKEFRONT DOCK - DREAM SEQUENCE

The same sailboat from the film reel, now moored between motor boats and pontoons. A bundle of pink CONGRATULATIONS BALLOONS bob, tied on the mast.

Monroe trips over Aurora's ART TOTE, abandoned on the grass. Her silhouetted figure skates along the deck, back to him.

AURORA (O.S.)
They're waiting for you, Monroe.

MONROE
Wait, Mom please don't leave--

She unfurls the sail -- it poofs into a barrier between them.

AURORA (O.S.)
If you don't move forward, you'll be left behind.

MONROE
Mom, stop. Please stop. Mom--

He grabs the SAIL. She pulls back, locked in a struggle--

MONROE (CONT'D)
I said stop -- STOP!

SLAM TO:

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

Monroe blinks awake in the frozen world. He stands on top of the BRIDGE FROM HIS DREAM, gripping the rail and looking out.

Trembling, he peels his fingers off, backing away from the edge, unveiling a **WHITE GAP** where he once stood. It's uncanny -- a boy-shaped hole in spacetime. Like a white silhouette.

He feels in his pocket, pulling out his phone, the screen forever aflame with **10:16 AM.** He stares, hyperventilating…

Then SMASHES it against the rail. OVER and OVER again. Until fragments of glass and plastic litter the brick.

A long beat. Then… The phone REBUILDS itself. Pristine again.

Monroe stares at those cold blue numbers with hatred.

EXT. BASEBALL FIELD - DAY

SLAM!! Monroe whacks a ball with a baseball bat. Behind him, a FATHER and SON play catch in the rain. The ball tries to reset after each hit, but Monroe intercepts its path.

Each hit flings the ball farther. SLAM… SLAM… SLAM…

CLOSE ON Monroe's glare, something brewing, as we roll into…

A "FIXING TIME" MONTAGE:

CANALS

Monroe races past boats, ducks under scaffolding, panting as he pushes himself faster than ever before.

PHYSICS CLASSROOM

Cracking his knuckles, Monroe opens a TEXTBOOK to a section on SPACETIME, ready to dive in.

SILO

Monroe selects the ELECTRIC GUITAR from his wall of floating objects. He clutches a book: 'Guitar for Beginners.'

His uneasy strums pierce through an otherwise silent world.

UNDER THE CANAL BRIDGE

Monroe secures Mr. Wellington's jacket to Nolan as if completing a Jenga tower, then cautiously backs away.

SILO

CLOSE ON, "*Every day is a new beginning!*" again.

Monroe tears off the date from the inspiration calendar.

PHYSICS CLASSROOM

Monroe's various notes fade into dust on the chalkboard:

- Help people? Nolan's jacket?

- Get better at things? Guitar!

- Find time remote and press play?

COMMUNITY CENTER - GALLERY

At his blank exhibit, Monroe "hangs" a PHOTO of the lighthouse. Tilts it. Considers it. Hmmmm.

UNDER THE CANAL BRIDGE

Nolan's sleeves swat the back of Monroe's head as it hovers back to Mr. Wellington… Monroe growls.

SILO

10:16 soars across the room and bursts apart on the wall.

BASEBALL FIELD

SLAM. SLAM. SLAM. Monroe hits the ball faster.

BATHROOM

Monroe lowers the toilet seat… It springs back up. *GAAH!*

SILO

"Every day is a new begin--" RIIIIP--

WELLINGTON MANSION - KITCHEN

SNAP! Monroe practices his chords for Mrs. Wellington. SNAPS a string. Curses. Waits for it to reset… and gets back at it.

SILO

A snoring Monroe floats upside down among his POLAROIDS -- his body RESETTING against the wall like a bat.

He snorts awake and falls on his head with a THUMP.

CANALS

Monroe loses his footing and TRIPS. He stays down heaving, glaring up at Fred, the struggling jogger.

PHYSICS CLASSROOM

TIME-RELATED BOOKS float against the wall, open to different sections like a vertical desk.

Monroe reads one -- *"Time Management."* Nods. Walks over to read "*Time Traveler's Wife*."

UNDER THE CANAL BRIDGE

BEER BOTTLES litter the underside of the bridge. Liquid pools in Zero G. Monroe drains a bottle and offers one to Nolan.

MONROE
Naaah? Wuh? -- You some narc?

SILO

Frenetic fingers SHRED the quote calendar into confetti.

SALVAGE YARD

Monroe fires an already-lit BLOW TORCH at the PHONE.

It melts into liquid plastic, then oozes back together and reforms, infuriating him further.

MARINA

Monroe strums 'Happy Birthday to you' for Hazel, sitting beside her in the swan boat. He's getting better.

"KING'S GARDEN" - HEDGE MAZE

Monroe jogs through the hedge maze. Stops. Looks around. Runs the other way. Completely lost.

BASEBALL FIELD

SLAM. SLAM… CRASH! Monroe winces as SOMETHING FAR AWAY breaks.

STREETS

Monroe's snoring body floats across an intersection.

GARAGE BAND

Frozen amidst a neighborhood JAM SESSION, Monroe ROCKS OUT beside a punk SINGER frozen mid-thrust. Mistakes aside, he strums out 'Smoke on the Water' by Deep Purple on the guitar.

He finishes with style. Looks to his band members… Crickets.

OUTSIDE CONSTRUCTION SITE

Monroe spots his LOST BALL stuck behind an imposing GATE.

He *could* slip under the bar, grab it… but as he nears the site, TERROR FILLS HIM. He flees, leaving the ball.

STREETS

SNAP! SNAP! SNAP! Monroe takes pictures of everything -- Sidewalk crack? Pigeon shit? A broken pipe. A spider web.

FINCHWOOD BRIDGE

Monroe's body refills the **WHITE GAP** as he slumbers. He wakes up and leaps out of it as if it were toxic.

COMMUNITY CENTER - GALLERY

Monroe tears down the lighthouse. Hangs a photo of Nolan. No. Fred? No. A bird? No. A bridge? A frog? NO. NO. NO.--

PHYSICS CLASSROOM

WORMHOLE! 4TH DIMENSION! SPACETIME! Words flash by as Monroe reads his time books at an accelerating speed. Behind him, a new message fades on the chalkboard: CHANGE SOMETHING??

Monroe shuts the book with a resounding SLAAAAAA--

BASEBALL FIELD

---AAAAMMMM! Monroe smashes his phone with the bat, all his frustration erupting in a single, ANIMALISTIC SWING.

A beat. The phone doesn't return. Monroe breathes a moment of relief. *Something different?!*

Then the phone BURSTS onto the earth beside him like a COMET. He pounces on it -- clawing at the resetting swarm of glass, trying to keep it broken until-- ZZT!

OUCH! Monroe withdraws his hand.

A shard has BITTEN his finger. **RED** bubbles from the cut. *Our first instance of color leaking into Stillness.*

Monroe observes as his blood drips… Downward. And stays on the ground…

THE BLOOD DOES NOT RESET. Monroe points, excited--

MONROE
That's it! I can fix it! HEY WORLD--
(then realizes, empty)
I can fix it. That's how I… fix it.

As his tiny voice quivers, we **END MONTAGE**.

EXT. COMMUNITY CENTER, GALLERY - DAY

Monroe leans against his blank wall, picking at his scab, mesmerized by the oozing forward motion of his blood.

As if on automatic, he pops a photo from a frame and presses its GLASS EDGE to his wrist until he sees blood. Fascinated.

More blood. MORE. Oh shit, that's too much blood--

Scared, Monroe drops the frame. **HARD CUT TO**--

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

A red-tinged RAG now coiled around his wrist, Monroe leans over the rail, fiddling with the glass frame as he flips through a BROCHURE for a **CONSTRUCTION INTERNSHIP PROGRAM.**

"Building Dreams and Careers!" Men smile in SAFETY VESTS and HARD HATS, emulating teamwork and success. Earmarked pages and curriculum circled. A sticky note reads…

To discuss as a backup for next year? ~ Grant

(CONTINUED)

As he reads his proposed future, his sadness grows. His grip tightens on the glass, a crimson line forming. Tighter until--

With a brutal scream, he FLINGS the frame into the lake.

He waits for it to reset, wiping hot angry tears. Waits.

Confused, he peers out, surprised by what he sees:

When the glass impaled the lake, its momentum sliced SO FAR DOWNWARDS that time reset the water above BEFORE it could float back. *Locking it inside the wave. Like jello.*

A thought seizes him. A dark one.

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - LATER

A physics TEXTBOOK, one of Nolan's BLACK POTS, his PHONE -- all float beside the broken frame, trapped beneath the gelatinous surface like dinosaurs in tar.

SPLASH! A SIX-PACK of beer joins the sacrificial array. On the bridge above, Monroe leans over, studying how the beer tries to reset -- floating up a moment before the oozing canal resets faster, and seals it underneath.

Satisfied with this calculation, Monroe climbs onto the railing. Scans nervously… *is this high enough?*

He looks over to a support beam with a maintenance ladder--

MOMENTS LATER

On top of the beam, Monroe takes in the hypnotic sea of frozen rain rushing toward infinity in lattice-like arrays.

Hyperventilating, he freezes. *Is he really going to do this?*

He glances below at an empty bollard on the dock where his mom's boat once was.

Now only her ABANDONED ART TOTE and an empty can of TURPENTINE remain. Stark reminders of her absence.

Resolute, he assumes a "pencil-shape" position.

Takes a step off, his leg hovering over the platform, when--

WHAM!

A BASEBALL smacks the back of his head.

GIRL (O.S.)
OH MY GOD, YOU MOVED.

His jaw drops as he spots the culprit, a **GIRL** (18), in a pale pink dress, now fleeing full speed in the opposite direction.

Off Monroe, desperately confused as he chases after her--

EXT. BUS STOP - MOMENTS LATER

Monroe runs past a BUS PATRON as he searches the streets.

MONROE
Excuse me, have you seen a girl?
With hair? Maybe *moving*?

Out of breath, he reaches the bus stop, where now sits a girl-shaped **WHITE GAP**, similar to his on the bridge.

Dumbstruck, he stares at it. Waves his hand in front of it.

Inches closer -- then leaps back… Nothing? So Monroe sits beside it, scratching his head. Amazed.

SWISH--SWISH. The soft brush might as well be a monster truck in the quiet. Monroe bends under the seat.

A BUS TICKET resets against a bench leg. He picks it up.

He twists his hand -- the **PAPER CURLS THE SAME DIRECTION** no matter which way he faces it. A compass of sorts.

Curious, he tosses the paper up. It floats horizontally--

EXT. CANALS - DAY

--Zooming over the water. Monroe jogs along the towpath parallel to it. The ticket swerves, snagging on a lamppost.

Monroe grabs a CROWBAR from a nearby WORKER and reaches up to free it. The ticket continues, floating toward the lake.

EXT. COASTAL OUTLOOK - DAY

TELESCOPE POV from across the bridge, pointed at Monroe as he races after the TICKET soaring ahead of him.

A BLUR OF MOVEMENT behind the scope catches Monroe's eye as the ticket dives into the figure's pocket. He waves!

MONROE
Hello?? GIRL?! ARE YOU REAL?

From the **TELESCOPE POV,** a random man waving. With a crowbar.

She steps out from behind the scope and he gasps -- CAUSE THERE SHE IS! The Girl. In all her teenage glory. *Moving*!

MONROE (CONT'D)
I'M MONROE. NICE TO MEET--

Moving… *away from him?* Yep, there she goes -- sprinting out from behind the scope and into the mist.

He remembers the crowbar still in his grip and drops it.

EXT. STREETS - MOMENTS LATER

Monroe dashes through frozen traffic, searching.

A flash of PINK up ahead -- it's her! She turns around to check and-- he LEAPS behind a car. Waits for her to continue…

She does. Monroe peeks out. Gets an idea.

EXT. CANALS - DAY

THUMP THUMP as the Girl crosses a wooden towpath. Monroe matches his footsteps with hers to hide the sound.

She freezes. A THUMP hits just a *microsecond* too late. Twists around to see--

Monroe. Frozen mid-jog, pretending to high-five Fred.

Suspicious, she narrows her eyes and quickens her pace.

EXT. MARINA/BEACH - DAY

Humming a casual tune now, the Girl playfully flicks the raindrops. Monroe weaves between boats behind her.

She passes behind a large boat, Monroe loses sight of her and rushes to keep up, turning the corner to see--

SHE'S FROZEN now. Innocently standing under an umbrella.

Disappointed, Monroe approaches, leaning in, studying her.

He leans even closer. Until he can see every pore… Curious, he reaches out to touch her WHITE SCARF and--

SLAP!!!

Monroe YELPS in pain.

GIRL
STOP FOLLOWING ME, CREEP!

MONROE
I wasn't--

GIRL
Then what were you doing?!

MONROE
I… I just wanted to talk to you.

She folds her arms. For the first time, Monroe gets a full look at her -- endlessly tired. A loner. Popular kids pick on this type of girl.

She wears a CROSS and a BACKPACK shaped like a HIPPO, decorated with pins of animals from around the world.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Um, hi.

GIRL
Hi?

She waits for more. There isn't… She rolls her eyes and stomps off along a sandy ridge leading to the beach.

MONROE
Wait! Um…

Monroe follows, desperate to keep this conversation going. He spots a pin on her backpack with a name -- **"GILLY"**.

MONROE (CONT'D)
--Gilly, right? Welcome to Stillness! That's what I like to call it. I know it's confusing, but I swear it's not so bad… It's actually great if you tend to lose stuff since it all floats back to where you found it anyway…
(she keeps walking)
I taught myself to play guitar! Maybe I could show you sometime?
(still nothing)
Is anyone else moving?

She suddenly flips around, terrified at that notion.

GILLY
No? I don't know! Are they? What did you-- is it starting?

MONROE
Time? No, it's just me-- us?

She turns back, picking up her pace. Monroe gets frustrated.

MONROE (CONT'D)
But ignoring me won't make me frozen!

GILLY
Not if you're-- you're a VERY convincing hallucination!!

MONROE
Oh yeah, could a hallucination do *this*?

Monroe jumps in front of her, snatching THREE PARASOLS and juggling them HORIZONTALLY. As they try to reset, he spins the parasols in an odd circus act.

The ridiculous visual just makes Gilly pale.

GILLY
No no no-- this can't be-- GO AWAY!

She LEAPS off the hill, kicking up a CLOUD OF SAND like a smoke bomb. Monroe slides down, but she's gone. A trail of DISAPPEARING FOOTPRINTS snakes down the beach.

Fascinated, Monroe rubs his cheek and follows.

EXT. CHURCH - DAY

Modest yet intimidating in its sterile archways. Monroe clocks the motion of a CLOSING DOOR and enters.

INT. CHURCH - CONTINUOUS

In front of the altar, a PASTOR kneels. Rows of frozen CHURCHGOERS pray in silent reflection. A serious service. A rack of votive candles radiates rosy, frozen firelight.

Monroe winds between bodies -- spotting a white scarf wrapped around her gnarled, curly hair. He kneels beside Gilly.

Gilly, irked, slides away. They pray in silence. Beat. Beat. Beat. Then--

GILLY
Are you even religious?

MONROE
Not really, but it's just nice to have someone to talk to, right?

GILLY
Not unless that *someone* wants something from you...

Monroe notices a RIP in Gilly's scarf. She tucks it in.

He then takes in the church… WHITE STAINED GLASS WINDOWS spill silver shadows across the pews. Not a drop of color.

MONROE
It's weird. Growing up, my mom never took me near this church. I've been everywhere in town but here. It's um… not what I expected. Like, all the colors of the rainbow, and the architect chose ONLY white? It's… clean, I guess.

But Gilly's expression carries disdain, her eyes locked on the **KING CO LOGO** branded into the window's corner.

GILLY
It's soulless. The whole town is like God spilled milk.

MONROE
So does that make us… Latte art?

She stifles a giggle. And the sound *just melts Monroe's heart*.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Take it you're not from here?

GILLY
No. I was just waiting for a bus, and… guess you could say I got "caught up in the moment"?

Monroe snickers, and similarly -- Gilly *also* melts at the sound. They bask in silence, but something bothers her.

GILLY (CONT'D)
"Gilly" -- why did you call me that?

MONROE
It's your name, right?

He points to the "GILLY" pin on her backpack. She grins at it with fondness, almost as if it had slipped her mind.

GILLY
Oh, right. Yeah.

MONROE
I'm Monroe.

Monroe offers a hand to shake. She shakes it, still unsure.

GILLY
Sorry about before, I'm not used to--

MONROE
People?

GILLY
People talking BACK to me.

MONROE
Ah, but you *are* used to hitting them with a baseball?

GILLY
You know how many people I've hit with baseballs here who *haven't* started chasing me with a crowbar?

MONROE
Right, sorry about that.
(beat, then realizing)
Wait, how long have you been here?

GILLY
Oh, uh, long enough.

Suddenly nervous, Gilly rises to leave.

GILLY (CONT'D)
I should probably go somewhere… else.

MONROE
Wait, if it's just us-- if we're the only two… What if there's a reason?

GILLY
You think there's a reason time stopped and the only other person moving is a guy juggling umbrellas? No. There's no reason for all this.

She slides past the row of CHURCHGOERS. Monroe rises.

MONROE
Even so, wouldn't it be nice to have some company? At least while we're stuck here?

He watches her stall in the aisle, divided.

GILLY
What makes you think I'm stuck?

MONROE
Isn't everyone here stuck?

GILLY
Only the ones who don't want to be. The rest of us… We don't mind the quiet and the…

MONROE
Stillness?

Gilly raises a brow. She likes that word.

GILLY
Yeah. People tend to ruin… that.

Monroe points to MIRANDA, hiding under a comically large hat.

MONROE
What?! You're telling me that Miranda's hot air balloon hat isn't the epitome of tranquility?

GILLY
No, no-- that hat's cause she wants to catch Vince sleeping with Becca.

MONROE
Is he??

GILLY
God, no… He's sleeping with BRIAN!

GASP! Gilly grows more animated as she gossips -- motioning to BRIAN, a redhead in a wool sweater.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Vince has wool under his nails. Oh and if you go back to his closet, there's a *red* hair--- WHAT?

Monroe's mouth hangs open…

MONROE
Wanna meet my friends?

A beat. Gilly's eyes betray her dying curiosity--

GILLY
Only if you promise not to juggle anything.

EXT. CANALS - DAY

BIRD'S EYE: We follow **two** trails of twinkling droplets as they weave between the motionless commuters and cyclists. Monroe and Gilly walk side-by-side, gossiping intimately.

GILLY (PRE-LAP)
Head over heels.

EXT. COASTAL OUTLOOK - DAY

They inspect Natalie and Maxine as if studying an art piece.

MONROE
I knew it.

GILLY
No doubt in my mind.

MONROE
I'm almost jealous of them.

GILLY
Meh, you never know. Might not like time one second forward. Maybe it's for the best it froze right here, right now.

That disturbs Monroe. He shakes it off, probing further.

MONROE
Well, how do you know she *hasn't* already said yes?

GILLY
Body language. Natalie is leaning in. Max isn't so sure yet.

MONROE
(he doesn't)
Hmm, yes… I see.

Gilly watches him struggle with amusement.

GILLY
Max got accepted into Columbia to study ornithology. But Natalie wants to stay close to her family, start a knitting business.

She pats his shoulder as she walks off.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Have a little imagination, Monroe.

EXT. UNDER THE CANAL BRIDGE - DAY

Next, Gilly and Monroe pace around Nolan. Gilly focuses on a tan line on his left ring finger.

GILLY
See you're right about the divorce…
But he's not homeless--

She shifts through Nolan's bag, holding up his HOUSE KEY.

GILLY (CONT'D)
He just didn't want that life.

BLACK POTS decorate his camp, glimmering like onyx gemstones.

Monroe flips over Nolan's cardboard sign: 'POTTERY FOR SALE.'

MONROE
So he CHOSE to be a starving artist instead?

GILLY
Not everyone's built for commitment.

MONROE
Yeah, neither was my biological dad…

Gilly swallows, finding Monroe's sudden sadness unsettling.

GILLY
Was he also into… pottery?

MONROE
Wish I knew. Didn't even leave me a cool backstory.

GILLY
Make one up then. My mom was a field zoologist. I like to imagine all the cool places she traveled to before she died…

She twirls the animal PINS on her backpack -- a kangaroo for Australia, a lion for Africa, a penguin for Antarctica, etc…

MONROE
Whoa, which one of those "fields" did you call home?

GILLY
Oh, um none of them really. Let's just say…
(beat, uncomfortable)
I didn't grow up like most kids.

MONROE
I'm sorry. I didn't mean to--

GILLY
Don't be. I'm free here… No one to answer to-- like our friend Nolan.

Monroe pulls Nolan's sleeve up to reveal a faded BATMAN WATER TATTOO on his wrist. Crooked. Placed by a loved one.

MONROE
He might've had… *someone* to answer to. At home.

The two share a disappointed sigh.

INT. CONVENIENCE STORE - DAY

Gilly stands in front of the beer section as Monroe retrieves a floating MASON JAR stored under the cash register.

He swipes a beer and raises it above his head… Then SHATTERS it against a shelf! The glass explodes.

As the contents assemble into a suspended bottle-shaped blob, Monroe TRAPS the liquid in the jar, sealing his prey shut.

MONROE
See? Like catching fireflies.

GILLY
Funny way to buy a girl a drink…
(re: jar)
Only one?

MONROE
Not like I get many visitors.

The now EMPTY bottle returns to the shelf, where Gilly raises a judgmental brow at an array of already EMPTY BOTTLES.

MONROE (CONT'D)
What?

GILLY
I don't know. You have the infinite powers of backwards time and you choose to use it on… floaty-beer pong?

Monroe blushes. She meanders toward a PARTY SUPPLIES display.

MONROE
Well, what would you use it on?!

Gilly POPS a balloon -- *SHWOOP*! As the latex reforms, she SWATS her hand INSIDE the expanding bubble, forming--

GILLY
How about… BALLOON HANDS!

Off their uproarious laughter--

EXT. "KING'S GARDEN", COURTYARD - DAY

Laughter dances through the lush greenery as they pass the beer back and forth, their stories mingling among the romantic scenery.

GILLY
--Seriously? How'd you fall asleep on TOP of a pergola*?*

MONROE
Surprisingly good back support! Until I woke up upside down on a clothesline… tangled in thongs.

GILLY
Rookie mistake.

They reach the fairytale-like courtyard. Gilly fixates on the KING STATUE, making an *'ick!'* noise.

MONROE
Oh, come on! I think it's romantic.

GILLY
Statues are for people who love their own face… and rocks.

Monroe observes how Gilly side-eyes the MISSING QUEEN statue.

MONROE
But there's something sweet about it, you know? It's Pygmalion. The king who fell in love with a statue and magically brought her to life?

GILLY
And what? She took one look at him and 'magically' filed for a divorce?

MONROE
It's even called "King's Garden--"

GILLY
Sparrow's Garden-- is what it used to be called. Because of all the birds that migrated through here.

She gracefully scales a TOPIARY ELEPHANT, perching on its back like a skilled circus performer. She tries to crane her neck over the hedge maze to look out at the lake.

GILLY (CONT'D)
It used to be this peaceful little sanctuary overlooking the lake.
(motions at courtyard)
Not all this Medieval Times crap...

A tinge of nostalgia underscores her callous tone. She shrugs, and peers down at Monroe's perplexed face below.

MONROE
You talk as if you've seen it.

GILLY
Psh. Nah, I've read the entire library archives like five times. Not like I can check my email here.

He scrambles up the TOPIARY FROG beside her, desperately trying to look cool while Gilly does so effortlessly.

MONROE
Oh, expecting some spicy DMs, Gilly?

GILLY
What? Is that a hot sauce?

MONROE
PMs? IMs? Snaps? Slips? Don't tell me you're on Mastodon.

Gilly stares at him as if he were speaking another language.

GILLY
Oh. No, I was just kind of… sheltered?

MONROE
Like… "mole people" sheltered?

GILLY
No like "waking up to a stained glass angel on my bedroom window for eighteen years" sheltered.

MONROE
Wooooow. How'd you survive that?

GILLY
I gave her a <u>voluptuous</u> mustache.

He chuckles, seeing how she fiddles with her CROSS necklace.

MONROE
Sometimes I wished I believed in that stuff more. Seems… hopeful.

GILLY
Honestly, when you grow up like I did, it shapes your worldview no matter what you believe in.

Gilly climbs down, wandering through the garden. Monroe follows, trying to lighten the mood.

MONROE
So what do you think happened here? The Big G upstairs fell asleep at the cosmic control panel?

GILLY
I've gone through all the obvious theories -- government experiment, Matrix glitch, aliens…

MONROE
Immersive theater troupe, bad edibles…

GILLY
Spontaneous rapture…

MONROE
We're stuck in a video game waiting for the player to press start…

She laughs, but a pulse of unassuming emotion quells her.

GILLY
I guess I realized after so long, you don't have to understand it to be at peace with it. The moment you do that…

As her eyes close, *we hear the lapping of waves, bustling of cars, children playing soccer…* as DISTANT SOUNDS of the town fade in. Dulcet memories of timing moving forward.

GILLY (CONT'D)
It's like the world comes to life again.

She plucks a red ROSE. Inhales deeply as the sounds evaporate.

She slips the rose behind Monroe's ear. He blushes, tightening the bandage on his wrist, noticing a line of red.

The FORCEFUL BASS of "*Smoke on the Water*" thumps in…

INT. WELLINGTON MANSION, LIVING ROOM - LATER

Monroe strums the song on his electric guitar. Gilly bobs her head and dances on a table as if they were at a RAGER!

As the song reaches a climax, Monroe SMASHES THE GUITAR over his head. Gilly kicks a fancy vase for good measure.

The two collapse on the couch, catching their breath.

GILLY
If I ever own a house, it'll have a chocolate fountain. And a shark tank. And a trained parrot that says 'ding-dong' instead of a doorbell… And one of those fancy rooms just dedicated to taking off your shoes!

Monroe kneels, transforming into her British butler.

MONROE
Welcome mademoiselle. Shall I remove your moccasins?

She laughs as he slides off her shoes -- **YELLOW PAINT** cakes the bottoms. Old paint. From a different time.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Hey, what was time like for you when it stopped?

Gilly recoils her feet, a hint of nervousness creeping in.

GILLY
Oh, I was waiting for my bus and it started snowing, and… that's it.

Monroe tilts his head, suspecting more. Gilly squirms away.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Funny thing is, I've been here so long, I can't really remember.

MONROE
That doesn't bother you?

Gilly drifts to a window, pulling out a stack of POSTCARDS.

GILLY
What bothers me is there's a whole world out there and I can't explore it all before I float back to that stupid bus stop.

MONROE
Where would you go?

(CONTINUED)

GILLY
Well, someplace with sunshine for starters.

She hands the stack to Monroe. He flips past postcards of Africa, Japan, Fiji… Love letters on the back of each.

GILLY (CONT'D)
But honestly… anywhere she's been.

MONROE
In that case, I hope your dad is a private pilot or something.

A sudden flicker of darkness at the mention of her father.

GILLY
He's--was… no one. But yeah, before they had me, I'm sure it was probably some fairytale life.

Inspired, Monroe sits up taller and with too much enthusiasm--

MONROE
Okay, hear me out… What if we're trapped in a fairytale, and the only way to break the spell is to--

Gilly just BURSTS out laughing. Monroe bristles.

GILLY
You can't even grow a real beard.

MONROE
HEY. Things don't really… grow here.
(feels peach fuzz)
Besides, if it's just us, don't we have a duty to, like, repopulate the world or something?

Gilly throws on Mr. Wellington's FANCY JACKET and briefcase.

GILLY
Well honey, with your spending habits, I'll have to work overtime.

Monroe throws on an apron, pretending to cook in the kitchen.

MONROE
You won't be home for dinner? After I slaved away!

GILLY
Sorry. I'm fully booked hurling baseballs at frozen people today.

Gilly grabs an APPLE. She dramatically winds up and hurls AN IMPRESSIVE BASEBALL PITCH! It crashes out a window then--

BOOMERANGS back inside, breaking everything in its path!

Their laughter echoes through the mahogany halls, as the ghostly force cleans up their tantrum like an annoyed parent.

MONROE (PRE-LAP)
No no no, you seriously think the Bennewitzes have the comfiest bed?

INT. SILO - DAY

Along his **"CAPTURING STILLNESS"** wall, Monroe has carved out a space for polaroids of various HOUSES, arranged in a TOURNAMENT-STYLE BRACKET. He argues a passionate case.

MONROE
It's gotta be the Meklers -- that water bed is like sleeping on a marshmallow sea of unicorn dreams!

Gilly gestures to another HOUSE like a lawyer.

GILLY
BUT the Bennewitzes have a running shower. That's a rare find here.

MONROE
Yeah, but you have to be okay with Larry's piercing eyes.

Monroe indicates a corner of the house's window where LARRY lurks, the man's unnerving gaze somehow fixated on the viewer. Gilly takes a closer look and grimaces.

MONROE (CONT'D)
That settles it. Meklers take the crown for best bed, Wellingtons for best pizza toppings, and Amicks for most unsettling mannequin display--

A photo of a FAMILY OF FIVE, sitting cross-legged around a CAT.

MONROE (CONT'D)
(takes out camera)
And then there's us! The most… "moving" of Stillness?

He sheepishly wraps his arm around Gilly -- SNAP! Monroe laughs as the selfie develops. She's snuck in bunny ears.

Monroe plops onto his bean bag. He takes down an artsy photo of the LIGHTHOUSE and shows it to her.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Hey, what do you think of this one?

GILLY
It's cool, I guess.

Her nonchalantness agitates him. He shuffles through more.

MONROE
What about this one? Or this one?

GILLY
They're all cool. Why?

MONROE
Ugh, cool isn't enough. I had this important show the day time stopped, and I still needed to choose a photo to build my exhibit around.

Gilly shrugs and grabs the photo of Larry.

GILLY
Just pick one. Here--

MONROE
It can't just be ANY photo. It's gotta be the RIGHT photo. Something with a "wow" factor. Something that will move my life forward, move everything… *"here"* forward.

GILLY
Wait, you seriously think <u>a photo</u> will fix time?

Monroe grows flustered, realizing how ridiculous it sounds.

MONROE
I mean, yeah. It's gotta be. I was holding my camera when time stopped so photos are the only thing I can change. The only other thing was…

His gaze drops to his cut wrist under his sleeve, disturbed by that thought. He shakes it off.

Gilly ambles through his gallery. She taps a photo as if it were a fish in a fish tank, annoying him.

MONROE (CONT'D)
So what do <u>*you*</u> do here?

GILLY
What do you mean by ‘do’?

MONROE
How do you keep busy?

GILLY
Why do I have to ‘keep busy’?

MONROE
It just seems like such a waste of…

Gilly watches him struggle with word choice, amused. She spots a COLLEGE HANDBOOK hidden under some trash. Transported, she plucks it out and flips through it.

Monroe detects a painful longing in Gilly’s eyes.

MONROE (CONT’D)
Were you gonna go somewhere?

GILLY
University of Stillness, obviously. You?

MONROE
Maybe one day. I took a gap year.

GILLY
Aren’t you supposed to leave home for those?

MONROE
(blushing)
Yeah, well… not always…

GILLY
Ooooh, don’t tell me you knocked up some chick--

MONROE
No, no it’s not that. It’s… I’m waiting for the right photography fellowship to come along.

GILLY
The right photo. The right fellowship. Holding out for the universe at every angle, Monroe?

Gilly smirks, but Monroe devolves into a rambling mess.

MONROE
Yeah, I know. It's just Getty, Sony World… even Nat Geo called. And every time I try to decide it's like I'm at a fork in the road. But every possible fork is also a fork in every possible multiverse, and all those forks fork, twisting around my chest like a straitjacket until I can't breathe and… and… Does that make any sense?

She stares at him, sensing more. Then--

GILLY
Yeah, you're one of those assholes who take forever to order at restaurants.

Off Monroe's relief--

INT. THE BIRDHOUSE DINER - DAY

A 1950s 'bird-themed' diner with ROOSTER artwork.

GILLY
Order up! I got a number two on stilts MADE TO FLY.

Gilly flings a stack of PANCAKES from the kitchen. As they fly back, Monroe forks the chunks, mid-air and mid-gossip.

MONROE
NO WAY! Please tell me you nailed that bastard right in his topee!
(adding)
Can I get some syrup?

PSSSSH! Gilly has rerouted a soda gun into a syrup bottle. Monroe jams a bendy straw into a sticky blob and drains it.

GILLY
Better. After Jenkins gave me the boot, I grabbed the first thing in the trash, which just so happened to be a can of expired squid ink from the Japanese place next door!

MONROE
NO.

GILLY
YES. And I hurled that sucker so hard onto the roof, ink exploded all over his stupid rooster.

Monroe chuckles at his photo of the infamous befouled ROOSTER WEATHERVANE with the ink stain atop 'The Birdhouse Diner.'

MONROE
Mystery solved. No wonder he never cleaned it. Too ashamed of his floppy pancakes.

GILLY
And too broke! Ugh, why couldn't time freeze for us in, like, Fiji? This town hasn't changed in decades. It's like a museum. Stuck in the past…

MONROE
Okay, new theory… what if everyone is actually moving really slow, and we're just moving at normal speed?

Monroe pretends to move in SLOW MOTION, hurling a PIE SLICE across the room. As it resets, he stands behind it with an open mouth, skillfully catching bits like a Hungry Hippo.

Gilly laughs, wiping a smudge of cream off his forehead. It's a tender moment, one that spurs a hint of worry.

GILLY
What were you doing on that bridge? When I first saw you?

His smile evaporates, the darkness resurfacing.

MONROE
You ever get tough thoughts? Like the kind of thoughts that feel like they could last forever?

Gilly withdraws, taken aback by his solemn shift.

GILLY
"Forever" is kind of a useless word. Nothing a person can do or feel or make can truly last forever. So why bother thinking about it, right?

MONROE
(beat, then suddenly--)
Death is forever.

Monroe offers it like a test, sensing her unease. But Gilly, ever defiant, quickly shields herself behind a wall of humor.

GILLY
Well, clearly you haven't heard the national anthem of Stillness--

Gilly runs to the jukebox and clicks it on. She belts out *'Waiting on the World to Change'* by John Mayer. Monroe covers his ears in horror. The song REWINDS and repeats.

GILLY (CONT'D)
It's frozen on the chorus so it only plays this part on loop--
(singing)
WAITING ON THE WORLD TO CHANGE--

PSSSH! Monroe blasts the SYRUP gun at her, soaking her in amber goo. Gilly giggles. A beat, then…

MONROE
Dammit, it's stuck in my head now.

The LOOPING CHORUS softens into the score, carrying us into…

EXT. FREIGHT TRAIN - *SERIES OF SHOTS*

Monroe and Gilly stroll along the top of a FREIGHT TRAIN, arms spread out like wings. *We hear their conversation--*

MONROE (V.O.)
Here's a good one -- would you rather be trapped in the past? Or far in the future?

GILLY (V.O.)
Oh, that depends. Is my mom hitting on me in the past?

Monroe turns to find Gilly distracted by a vivid BUTTERFLY, suspended mid-air. Smitten, he joins her in childlike wonder.

MONROE (V.O.)
Only if you want her to?

GILLY (V.O.)
Sweet. Definitely the past.

LATER -- Gilly marvels as Monroe shows her a hidden train car, spray-painted with the swirly GRAFFITI OF A BUTTERFLY.

EXT. MARINA - MOMENTS LATER

The horizon glows eternal grey as they tread along the docks, their footfalls a gentle percussion on the aged planks.

The CONSTRUCTION SITE looms larger and closer.

GILLY
Okay, your turn -- would you rather be stuck in a world where photography doesn't exist or in a world where it *does*, but you can only take photos of…
(weird voice, wags pinkie)
My weee-ittle finger?

MONROE
Easy. Doesn't exist.

GILLY
Damn. You answered that too fast.

MONROE
As much as I love… Sir Gilbert Gottfinger -- the same photo? Every day? I'd rather be frozen forever than trapped in some endless loop.

GILLY
Not a fan of "Groundhog Day", I take it?

Monroe points to a BUS, driving along the lakefront.

MONROE
See that bus? Monday through Friday for nine years, my stepdad boarded the 8:50. Same job. Same company. Same yellow vest. It only sunk in just how sad it was when I did this time-lapse for class at the bus stop. And there he was, yellow blazing in the background of every shot. Even today, he's at some big important meeting.

GILLY
No wonder adults are so sad. Paying taxes. Calling plumbers…

MONROE
Making "backup" plans… Ordering the hot sauce ON THE SIDE…

They pass ELLIE and JASON, bickering in the SWAN BOAT.

GILLY
Can you imagine? Being a parent at OUR age?

Gilly frowns at their daughter, HAZEL, voice tinged in sorrow. Monroe observes Gilly's mood shift… gets an idea.

MONROE
What do you mean? Ellie's parents were thrilled. They even babysit once a week. Thanksgiving is weird but that's just cause Aunt Janet keeps flirting with Jason's dad.

She cracks a smile, skipping onto a moored YACHT.

Monroe follows onboard, and the two stroll along the deck.

GILLY
Monroe was raised by lamas in the Amazon. He has an extra toe on his left foot.

MONROE
Gilly moonlights as a professional ballroom dancer…

Monroe takes her hand, leading her to the bow of the ship.

GILLY
No… Monroe. I'm not gonna--

MONROE
C'mon, Gilly. Have a little imagination.

As Monroe twirls her, she relaxes. They dance as teenagers do -- clumsy and awkward, but brimming with heart. Limbs flail as they sway to some beat only they can hear.

They spin faster -- the CONSTRUCTION SITE whipping by in dark fragments until -- suddenly GILLY stops, curious.

GILLY
Has that always been there?

She squints at a tiny BLACK PLUME of smoke lurking on the far side of the construction site. Monroe's heart skips a beat.

As Gilly stretches for a pair of BINOCULARS on a table--

--Monroe hurls his BEER JAR that way, <u>deliberately knocking the binoculars</u> from her reach. And we watch--

FROM ABOVE as the raindrops shimmer in a serene ballet. Beer mixing with rain, staining the water flaxen…

…AND **RED**.

Because Monroe's BANDAGE has slipped off as well, splattering dollops of BLOOD as it frolics in the "wind."

Embarrassed, Monroe lunges for it, but it's too late… Gilly takes in the JAGGED SCAB snaking down Monroe's wrist, completely forgetting the binoculars.

A long beat as she absorbs this. Then, *WAY too cheerful*--

GILLY (CONT'D)
Want to feel what it's like to be Jesus?

MONROE
Isn't that offensive to--

She jumps off the boat. Monroe recaptures a blob of beer with his jar, taking a big swig before lowering his weight onto the jelly-like ripples. The lake undulates like a waterbed.

GILLY
Come on!

She drags him out further, their world forever a playground.

EXT. LAKE - DAY

Pontoons and jet skis mottle the reflective surface.

WIDE: Two lonesome dots skip and bounce over swells.

CLOSER: Monroe and Gilly approach the lake's center. Here, the waves bulge like alpines of chiseled gelatin. Gilly expertly navigates the chop, Monroe with less ease.

They reach a mountainous wave. Gilly passes the beer downhill.

For a moment, it floats away like a leaf in the wind. Monroe snatches it before it escapes.

Gilly scales a wave like a professional climber, fingertips dancing between crevices. She offers a hand to Monroe.

Monroe passes her the beer. Gilly tugs him to the top of a--

WAVE CREST

The crest resembles that of a mountain lookout, offering a humble plateau for the two to admire their vista:

SUNLIGHT carves through clouds. Splinters of light, frozen halfway to their destination. **The only sunshine we've seen.**

Monroe aims his camera. Gilly chuckles and shakes her head.

GILLY
It's not going anywhere.

He lowers his camera as her lips curve into a soft smile. Then she points to a spot on a lake--

A MURMURATION OF STARLINGS swirls in a black cloud. And it just so happens time stopped when they formed the shape of a GIANT STARLING. A bird made of birds!

MONROE
Whoa, what are the chances…

Monroe studies those birds. REALLY studies them. And without a lens to hide behind, TEARS suddenly swell at their beauty.

GILLY
What's wrong?

MONROE
Are we gods?

They absorb the wonder of their frozen kingdom.

EXT. LAKE, WAVE CREST - LATER

The two lie on their backs, staring up at the endless grey. The beer nears its end.

GILLY
I miss stars.

He points to a random cloud.

MONROE
Look, Orion's belt.
(she squints, confused)
Literally the only one I know.

Monroe adjusts on the ledge, closing his eyes.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Do you still dream in motion?

GILLY
I used to. Now, they're all these…
eerie Pompeii-like tableaus.

Gilly closes her eyes, remembering. Picks her words carefully.

GILLY (CONT'D)
I heard a story of these… swans
here? Glamorous white beasts. So
large they were almost prehistoric.

MONROE
Hmm, I've never seen a swan here.

GILLY
Right. They must have all left when that crazy construction started.

She sits up, referring to the CONSTRUCTION SITE offshore.

MONROE
I heard it was a museum… Or some fancy shopping mall?

GILLY
Maybe a large Hadron collider?

MONROE
An amusement park.

GILLY
One of those cafes where you order dinner while nerds joust for you?

MONROE
Who knows. This construction mogul bought it and skipped town randomly. But the city won't let anyone else develop there because they keep thinking he'll come back. King something or other--

GILLY
Milton. Milton King.

Monroe clocks the disgust relishing in her throat.

MONROE
You know him?

GILLY
Doesn't everyone here? This whole town is like some weird Ozymandian shrine to him.

MONROE
Well, maybe we're just a hopeful bunch.

He offers a genuine smile, but Gilly suddenly finds a loose thread on her scarf more interesting, remaining distant.

GILLY
Have you ever heard the Legend of Amah Rock? A fisherman's wife climbs a hill every day waiting for her husband to return, not knowing he perished at sea.
(MORE)

GILLY (CONT'D)
She waited so long, she transformed into a rock.
(ominous beat)
If King never comes back, you'll always wonder, always hope. That's how he stays alive… relevant… While we just wait for his work to rot in lake water.

A sense of foreboding hangs in the windless grey.

MONROE
Good.

GILLY
Why?

MONROE
Cause if we wait long enough, maybe the swans will come back.

GILLY
Or… we'll turn to stone.

Disturbed by that notion, Monroe picks at his SCAB…

MONROE
You ever think we're being punished?

Gilly touches her CROSS NECKLACE.

GILLY
What'd we do wrong?

MONROE
I don't know. Just feels like we're cheating or something.

GILLY
No deadlines. Nowhere to be--

MONROE
No one to spend it with?

GILLY
Well, not anymore.

Unwinding her scarf, she offers an edge to him as a pillow.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Even if you <u>are</u> just a hallucination.
(off Monroe, smiling)
If this is Hell, sign me up.

Monroe basks in the warmth of the moment, snuggling up. He sips the beer. Passes the final gulp to Gilly.

Gilly accepts, and maybe we haven't noticed until now but she **pretends to drink, letting the liquid escape instead.**

The empty jar sails back to shore as the two drift to sleep.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. AURORA'S SAILBOAT, LAKEFRONT DOCK - DREAM SEQUENCE

Right where we left off -- Monroe on the dock, Aurora on the boat, the sail stretched between like a paper umbilical cord.

MONROE
STOP!

SWOOSH -- an otherworldly-sized wave surges between them, buckling the deck beneath Monroe's feet. He staggers back, ripping off a STRIP OF CLOTH from the sail as he falls.

But as the cloth drops, its movement DRAGS, floating a second longer than in normal gravity. ***As if time were slowing down.***

Aurora returns to her CANVAS, now on an easel on the bow. She begins to paint, undeterred by the darkening sky.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Mom! Stop! There's a storm--

A demonic groan of THUNDER moans across the lake, but Aurora remains absorbed in her art, oblivious to the tempest.

AURORA (O.S.)
I have to finish this first. I'm so close. So close.

She traces a curve, painstakingly slowly.

MONROE
Hurry! Come back to shore!

On all fours, Monroe crawls along the heaving dock, grabbing the MOORING LINE as it flaps by in jagged slo-mo.

C-CRACK. But it's not lighting. Instead of a brush, Aurora suddenly wields a CHISEL, stabbing her canvas' white flesh with a fervor disproportionate to her calming tone.

AURORA (O.S.)
Don't wait for me, honey. Go ahead.

MONROE
I'm not going anywhere without you.

Time continues to stretch as an EMPTY PILL BOTTLE rolls past.

AURORA (O.S.)
Nonsense. You're missing out on all the fun! You have places to be, photos to take. There's a whole world out there waiting for you.

She splashes a canister of TURPENTINE along the deck as if it were a routine cleaning.

Monroe stares as the flammable paint thinner oozes forward toward him, now frozen in horror.

AURORA (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Monroe, you can't expect to move forward if you stand still. Go on now, silly goose.

MONROE
I-I don't know how.

A streak of lethargic LIGHTNING unfurls behind her, igniting the LIGHTHOUSE CLOCK as it ticks past 10.

AURORA (O.S.)
One step at a time and you'll see-- time has a way of healing itself.

MONROE
What's the point of having all the time in the world if I have NOTHING to fill it with?

CRACK! A boom of thunder. RAINDROPS begin to pelt down.

But the drops fall leisurely, as if through molasses -- trailing dark columns of ***GREY*** *as the colors of this dream start to wash away. Remnants of Stillness slipping through.*

AURORA (O.S.)
Fill it with color. Pink, blue, violet… Anything but white.

Her hand extends from behind the sail, entwining with his.

Their pinkies connect. Monroe stretches out, but the YELLOW OIL slickens her grip. As her boat begins to drift away...

AURORA (O.S.) (CONT'D)
And if you do… I'll be there. I promise. I'll be there.

POP! A chilling gust bursts one of the BALLOONS, bobbing wildly on the mast as the current finally claims her.

Desperate to keep her in sight, Monroe runs up the slope--

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER/DREAM SEQUENCE

BIRD'S EYE: *On the bridge, Monroe runs parallel to Aurora's boat below. Cars and cyclists zip past. Boats tread toward home. All inching forward in increasing slow motion.*

He reaches the rail, just in time to see her boat rocket out from beneath the bridge, aimed at the CONSTRUCTION SITE.

VA-VROOM! *A car engine startles him. Unnerved, Monroe turns to see a WHITE PONTIAC approaching.* ***As time slows to a crawl--***

SLAM TO:

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

Monroe's eyes open back at the **WHITE GAP**.

But he doesn't move. Just stares across the water… *Frozen??*

A pitiful WHIMPER escapes his lips… he shakes. Stuck.

His whimpers grow more desperate… Until finally…

His arm JOLTS upright! A slight CRACK -- FRACTURING an INVISIBLE SHELL that enveloped his body while he was still.

Catching his breath, he absorbs what just happened. He flexes his fingers, thankful for the movement.

He raises a hand to his **WHITE GAP** -- *SHLURP* -- as if he were MAGNETIZED, it wrenches him forward. He backs away, nervous.

MONROE
Gilly? Gilly GILLY GILLY--!

INT. CHURCH - DAY

He bursts through the aisle--

MONROE
Gilly!! We have a problem. Gilly? Are you here? Gilly-- dammit!
(realizes, to Pastor)
Oh!! Sorry, Father!

The PASTOR emits a domineering aura in his posture, frozen as he kneels before the altar.

A meditative beat -- something about it spurs Monroe to kneel.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Hey, don't suppose you know a way out of Hell?
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

MONROE (CONT'D)
(chuckles, then)
Forgive me, Father, for I have…
what am I doing here?
(beat, a dark moment)
I saw her that day… Why did she…
She was happy… She was--
(stops himself)
No. She was happy. I can be happy.

He feels the SCAB ON HIS WRIST, wrestling his own demons.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Time has a way of healing itself.

The Pastor's desperate grip on something intrigues Monroe.

On his alter, an aged postcard reads, '**Time is short.**' Monroe flips over an image of a simple and elegant park -- *Sparrow's Garden*, *Finchwood Lake*. SWANS dot the water.

Monroe furrows his brow. SUDDENLY a yelp in the distance--

GILLY (O.S.)
Ah! Not again.

EXT. BUS STOP - DAY

Monroe runs down the street to find a flailing Gilly, her cardigan tangled on a STREET LAMP as she floats like a flag.

Her ridiculous position incites laughter from Monroe.

GILLY
Stop laughing!! Get me down.

MONROE
How did you even--

GILLY
Oh you know, just going for my
daily street lamp inventory when--
HOW DO YOU THINK I GOT UP HERE?

MONROE
Hold on, hold on.

He scales a windowsill up a shop canopy and untangles her.

GILLY
I swear, this happens every time I
fall asleep east of the bench…

Like going down a slide, she rides the resetting force DOWN -- sucked back into her own **WHITE GAP** on the bench.

As Gilly rises -- *SHLURP*, the **WHITE GAP** magnetizes one of her legs like it did to Monroe. Horrified, she yanks as if her foot were stuck in mud -- POP! She tumbles into Monroe.

He catches her. They turn, taking in this scary new monster.

EXT. BUS STOP - MOMENTS LATER

SHLAP -- Gilly and Monroe dump BUCKETS OF OIL over the Gilly-shaped **WHITE GAP**, staining it a shiny black silhouette.

The oil haplessly reverses, its buckets swallowing it back.

GILLY
Gah, nothing's working!!

MONROE
Time *really* wants to reset everything. Even us.

Edging on panic, Gilly hastens down the street toward town--

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE/LAKEFRONT DOCK - MOMENTS LATER

Monroe chases after Gilly, trying to slow her.

MONROE
Wait-- where are you going?

GILLY
I don't know but on my list of horrible ways to go, losing a game of freeze tag to a spacetime hole ranks pretty high up there. C'mon, we have to get out of here.

MONROE
But-- we can't leave! Not now. Not when something's finally happening.

GILLY
The WRONG something? Did you see that thing almost eat my foot?

MONROE
But clearly us colliding set something in motion! Who knows? This could be good. This could be time starting to… "heal" itself.

Gilly stops, a jolt of terror striking her at that thought.

GILLY
How do we stop it?

MONROE
What? But-- why?

GILLY
I'm not gonna stay and let time "heal" over me like a scab. Is it spreading? Maybe we can outrun it.

MONROE
We'll just float back.

GILLY
Not if we keep moving! Take turns sleeping. Hold each other down.
(beat, excitement gaining)
I can't believe I didn't think of this before! This is how we escape!

Monroe's eyes widen in panic. She unfolds the FIJI POSTCARD.

GILLY (CONT'D)
With enough coffee, we can hike the Pacific and be beach bumming it by--

MONROE
(urgent, too fast)
There's nothing out there!

Gilly flinches, his abrupt fear startling her.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Nothing you can't see in a book. I've already gone as far as we can and there's no point. But us, here, in this town -- *that's* the point.
(gathers self)
Listen, whatever photo I'm supposed to take, I think you're supposed to be in it… Not running in circles forever. I promise when time moves forward, Fiji will still be there.

Crestfallen, she regards the horizon longingly.

GILLY
But so will traffic. And schedules.

MONROE
And sunshine. And music…

Monroe aims his lens down the lake-- SNAP, capturing a big FAMILY fleeing the rain. A tapestry of multigenerational joy.

MONROE (CONT'D)
And all the people who make this town so special. We can't just… leave them behind, right?

As he says this, his gaze falls to the LAKEFRONT DOCK, where his mom's abandoned art tote still lies.

He shows Gilly the lovely photo, but she shakes her head.

GILLY
Maybe I just see these people differently than you.

Monroe frowns, noticing how Aurora's SILVER PAINTBRUSH winks in the dim light. Off his intrigue, we hear… *SWOOOSH*--

INT./EXT. UNFINISHED OFFICE BUILDING - DAY

--as Monroe tugs down a tarp, unveiling a WHITE WALL behind it. The two stand in an under-construction office building.

Lumber and piping dot the cement. Ladders lean like sentinels guarding a gallery of unassembled cubicles. A small but mighty team of WORKERS are suspended in mid-laughter, stereo pumping.

We notice King's logo is absent here. A new one has taken its place. This is GIANT CO.

Monroe hangs a PHOTO OF THE TOWN on the wall. With a smile, he presses the PAINTBRUSH to Gilly's hand.

MONROE
Show me.

GILLY
Show you what?

MONROE
(indicates photo)
Show me how you see things. People. This town. A watermelon. Anything.

Monroe rummages through spare toolboxes and workspaces, selecting paints, pencils, and trays…

GILLY
You think, what-- if I paint the "right" picture, time will move forward?

MONROE
Doesn't have to be painting. Recite a poem, do a dance, weave a basket! I have my camera. Find your thing.

GILLY
I told you, I don't have a thing.

He turns to Gilly with the makeshift art supplies.

MONROE
Everyone has a thing. C'mon, we both need to do this.
(off her hesitation)
My mom always told me whatever you're afraid of is on the inside, not the outside. So try something for me -- take what's on the inside and put it on the outside. Capture it.

GILLY
What makes you think I'm afraid?

MONROE
Cause I would be too if I didn't have a home.

She dodges his earnest smile, feeling the soft bristles.

She dips the brush in paint and inches to the wall. Her hand TREMBLES, spewing droplets as she traces a line. That's all it is. A glorious **PINK** stroke across the white.

But of course, the color RESETS back into the bucket… swirling like a ribbon dancer's sash. As it fades, she lowers the brush. Shakes her head.

GILLY
What's the point? I'll never finish.

MONROE
Paint faster! I'll take a picture!

GILLY
No. No more pictures. You can't cram everything into your stupid camera frame all the time!

MONROE
Running away isn't always the answer--

GILLY
It is when it's from something terrible--

MONROE
Not to go 'shred the gnar' in Fiji!

S P U L A T !

PINK PAINT slaps Monroe's cheek.

GILLY
You're a privileged piece of shit, you know that?

As the color fades from his face, his temper boils. He spits out a chuck of **PINK**, steps forward--

…She readies her bucket. *Daring him*.

He unlatches a BUCKET OF **BLUE** PAINT. *WOOSH*!

Gilly ducks as the paint zips by -- striking a STACK OF CERAMIC TILES. They teeter precariously and CRASH! The two share mischievous grins…

<u>As it turns into an all-out **PAINT FIGHT**!!!</u>

- SPLAT SPLAT SPLAT! Monroe fires **blue** like a Gatling gun, bathing the walls as he chases Gilly through the floor.

- Gilly hurls paint at a LADDER. It topples over, puncturing a wall and raining **pink** drywall over Monroe.

- Monroe army crawls under a DESK behind Gilly, and DUMPS a can of paint on her. She screeches and returns fire.

Their laughter spills up the stairs, as they continue to the--

TOP FLOOR

From up here, we glimpse a once roaring BULLDOZER atop a parallel sandy hill, hauling tightly bound CONCRETE SLABS.

A rugged DEBRIS CHUTE connects the uneven floor to a scrap pile at the building's base. A row of WORKER LOCKERS lines a corner, each with a distinctive name tag.

As Gilly and Monroe play, splinters of wood and dust join dashes of **pink** and **blue**, decorating the ashen playground in winks of **violet.** Resetting as fast as the two exchange blows.

WACK! Gilly lands a gnarly glob at Monroe, who eats **pink**!

He trips into the LOCKERS. They topple like dominos, spilling wrenches, hammers, and drills as they flap open.

Personal effects whiz by -- a lunchbox, a yellow vest, a MODEL ROCKET… and a <u>flash of Monroe's smiling face?</u>?

Gilly double-takes -- clocking a **PHOTO OF YOUNG MONROE** as it slips back into the vents of a LOCKER, a label reads "GRANT."

Monroe begins to protest as Gilly opens the locker--

--pulling out a BUSINESS CARD with Grant's face on it.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Is that your stepdad? He runs Giant Co?

Without more paint-fueled chaos, the space rebuilds behind them, and the colors fade away.

MONROE
Yeah, Grant. He's a bit pathetic.

GILLY
What? No, it's not. Why?

MONROE
King Co still renews their legacy contracts even without him here. They edged Giant Co out years ago so he can't get anything worthwhile past the city.

Gilly rifles through dusty BLUEPRINTS and PROPOSALS and APPLICATIONS, each plastered with a burning 'REJECTED' stamp.

GILLY
Looks like he kept trying.

Monroe shrugs, quietly impressed by the stacks of attempts.

A MODEL ROCKET jammed between a stack of METAL DRUMS in a corner catches his attention. Nostalgic, he drifts over.

MONROE
He kept the old Apollo I built him?

He wiggles it free, accidentally setting the drum stack rolling around like billiards. One CAREENS over the edge--

--Rolling down the CHUTE. But its curvature, coupled with the drum's desire to reset up, just so happens to FLING it back to the top of the chute, where the motion repeats. Faster.

Creating <u>a perpetually accelerating feedback loop</u>.

MONROE (CONT'D)
It's a feedback loop! Get down!

Violent vibrations course through the floor, spilling a bag of NAILS atop a ladder. Monroe and Gilly take cover as nails ricochet around them like frenzied bullets.

They scramble down the stairs, fleeing--

OUTSIDE

Ducking behind a truck, they watch in horror/awe as the drum continues to roll around the chute… Sweeping up a colorful VORTEX of resetting debris as it spins. Faster. Faster. Until--

It bumps on a resetting nail, losing balance-- ***WA-WOOSH!*** THE DRUM LAUNCHES OFF THE TRACK LIKE A BOWLING BALL--

SMASHING into the bulldozer's load of CONCRETE SLABS.

For a moment, the slabs swarm like bees, but settle against their steadfast chains, the taut net inhibiting more chaos.

Monroe and Gilly sigh in relief as the place rebuilds -- the dented chute re-straightening, drums re-stacking, nails swept up. Everything returning to its place…

Everything… except a lone METAL DRUM, now SANDWICHED BETWEEN THE CONCRETE SLABS AND THE BULLDOZER, like a spring.

And you can almost *hear* the strain of the slabs trying to reset, compressing the drum between.

They back away from the dozer as if it were a loaded nuke.

INT./EXT. UNFINISHED OFFICE BUILDING - MOMENTS LATER

Back inside, Gilly and Monroe shelter against an open frame.

GILLY
This town wants us out.

MONROE
No, it desperately wants us to stay here. Specifically here--

He takes out photos of the **WHITE GAPS**, pointing.

MONROE (CONT'D)
And here. Everything wants to be back in its place. Including us. These spots have their own gravitational pull or something.

Gilly studies the MODEL ROCKET still in Monroe's grasp.

GILLY
Gravity-- that's it.

With a roguish grin, she swipes his rocket and raises it in front of the BULLDOZER… thinking.

ROCKET POV: The nozzle-side points DOWN THE HILL, the direction the dozer would roll if unleashed. The compressed concrete slabs align with the JET ENGINE.

GILLY (CONT'D)
C'mon. I have an idea.

Gilly drags a nervous Monroe into the bulldozer.

INT./EXT. BULLDOZER (PARKED) / TOP OF HILL - MOMENTS LATER

Gilly crawls into the cabin, checking brakes and mirrors.

She studies the spring-like mechanism of compressed slabs. Monroe scrambles into the passenger seat, nervous.

MONROE
Gilly… what are we doing?

GILLY
Just keep the wheel straight.

Obediently, Monroe takes it. Gilly rushes around to the--

BACK OF THE BULLDOZER

Gilly selects a SLEDGEHAMMER from a row of tools nearby. *BONG*! She swings at the METAL DRUM, wedging it free.

INSIDE THE BULLDOZER, Monroe feels the cabin shift, the wheels creak, releasing an avalanche of gravel. Monroe swallows, peeking down the treacherous drop. **Meanwhile--**

BONG! BONG! BONG! Gilly keeps striking until the drum is almost free, teetering on the edge of escape. Satisfied, she drops the hammer and climbs back into the driver's seat.

Monroe's anxiety has peaked as Gilly takes the wheel.

MONROE
What is happening--

GILLY
A rocket! We just need a "kick" to get past city limits. And then…

Gilly vigorously slams back and forth in the seat, trying to dislodge the drum that last inch.

GILLY (CONT'D)
…we'll be free of those things's "gravitational pull" or whatever--

MONROE
I-I've never left this town!
(beat, off her shock)
I lied. I just don't have anywhere to go.

Gilly stops a beat, then smiles reassuringly.

GILLY
Well, if you want to find that magic photo, Monroe, you gotta widen your lens, right?
(off his fear, earnest)
You can trust me, okay?

Monroe nods, then heaves back on the seat, joining her rhythm as they shake the drum free. One final joint shove and then--

CRUNK! The drum wizzes off -- the SLABS SNAP, ***like a SPRING expanding***, discharging an ENORMOUS ENERGY WAVE, and *thrusting them forward* as they LAUNCH down the hill--

INT./EXT. BULLDOZER (MOVING) / HILL - CONTINUOUS

STREAM ROLLING out of town! Monroe's shrieks morph into delight, as he realizes… *this is FUN?!* Gilly waves her hands above her head. He joins.

And soon they're howling with laughter, riding it like a VERY DESTRUCTIVE roller coaster, demolishing anything in its path.

TREES replace BUILDINGS. MARSH replaces CEMENT. As they zoom backward past the sign "**WELCOME TO FINCHWOOD LAKE.**"

But ahead, the CONSTRUCTION SITE looms closer, the thin plume of smoke darkening. Immediately, Monroe's smile evaporates.

MONROE
No no no no, I can't do this.

GILLY
Yes, you can! We have to keep--

Monroe seizes the wheel, spinning it through a gate. A tarp with KING'S LOGO snags the windshield, blocking their view--

DOWN A DIRT ROAD

As the smooth pavement gives way to a rickety path--

GILLY
NO-- MONROE, WHAT THE--

Gilly seizes the wheel, but Monroe won't relinquish it.

As they fight, the dozer SWERVES around a bend, careening over a massive dip, the ground VANISHES -- they soar -- !!!

ONE FINAL WHOPPING *SMAAAAASH* and **we SMASH TO**--

MOMENTS LATER

The dust has settled, revealing the BULLDOZER… NOW INVERTED.

…AND AT THE BOTTOM OF A DITCH!

Monroe glances at Gilly, who hacks up a lung of dirt.

MONROE
Gilly? Are you okay--

Beneath some minor gashes, she tries to pounce at him--

GILLY
What is your PROBLEM--!

But the LIFT BLADE has completely buckled back onto the driver cabin, pinning Gilly beneath.

MONROE
I'm sorry! I panicked!

CREEUNK! -- The dozer shifts -- depleted of its momentum now, it tries to roll back up.

But the ditch is too steep, the damage too severe… it only frees an AVALANCHE OF DEBRIS--

Which weighs the dozer back down… the motion repeats. As they cough, the dozer continues to rock back and forth in a perpetually deepening sinkhole, burrowing itself as it goes.

MONROE (CONT'D)
We need to get out before it traps us inside!

Monroe shimmies out the cabin window, but Gilly struggles, stuck beneath the BLADE. He HEAVES against the metal, but it just sinks deeper.

GILLY
Stop -- you're making it worse!

MONROE
We need more leverage! Let me…

He scampers out of the ditch. The backyard of a petite HOUSE with an OPEN WINDOW peeks out from the bush.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Just hold tight. There's a HOUSE--

GILLY
Do NOT go inside that house!

As she squirms, her HIPPO BACKPACK comes loose and floats up.

(CONTINUED)

MONROE
What? There's gotta be something inside that can help--

GILLY
MONROE, I SAID DO NOT--

MONROE
You're sinking!

GILLY
LET ME SINK THEN!

Monroe stares. She's breathless. Desperate.

MONROE
(appalled)
No.

He ascends the hill -- untamed ivy clambers the house's walls like a feral blanket. Antique gas lamps cast a sinister glow.

GILLY'S BACKPACK floats against a window. He nudges it aside.

GILLY
Monroe! MONROE!!-- DON'T--

Then he sees it -- a STAIN GLASS ANGEL with a GIANT MUSTACHE drawn on it. The one Gilly drew. A long angry beat as he opens the window and her backpack floats inside.

MONROE
Long way from home, aren't you Gilly?

GILLY
I can explain… Just, please. Don't go in…

Boiling with betrayal, Monroe yanks on a flimsy GUTTER PIPE.

MONROE
Why not? Your family must miss you--

GILLY
I'm sorry--

MONROE
Since you've been *lying* to me this entire time--

He RIPS the pipe off the wall and tosses it into the ditch.

CLOSE ON GILLY, using the pipe as leverage to prop a gap under the blade.

She crawls out of the hole, searching, but Monroe is gone.

INT. GILLY'S HOUSE, BEDROOM - MOMENTS LATER

A CRUCIFIX on a door. Lizzie McGuire rocks out beside Jesus. Graphic novels splayed between BIBLES. A heavily earmarked COLLEGE HANDBOOK, matching Monroe's.

A room warring between adolescence and childhood.

Monroe climbs in, steps closer… *CRUNCH*. At his feet, a CERAMIC SWAN with its neck broken off. He plucks a piece, but it just tumbles back to the floor. Already BROKEN.

A small SHRINE displays PHOTOS of a WOMAN in safari gear and Gilly's hippo backpack, posing with animals across the globe.

One image captures the Pastor and the WOMAN, hopelessly in love, as they feed birds at Sparrow's Garden, a serene oasis flourishing with flora and fauna from a more innocent time.

More of Gilly's POSTCARDS hang on a decorative string. But one stands out -- a haunting BLACK SQUARE.

Monroe approaches, flipping over an **ULTRASOUND OF A FETUS.**

GILLY (O.S.)
Did you know a fetus has webbed feet when it develops? I think it looks kind of like a sea monster.

At the window, Gilly traces her belly as if it were covered in toxic goo. She regards a PROTEST SIGN on the floor with disgust: 'Let God Plan Parenthood', 'Protect the Unborn!'

GILLY (CONT'D)
You spend your entire life playing this role. The perfect daughter. Perfect student. Perfect youth leader… until suddenly find yourself making an appointment 200 miles away ready to throw it all away.

She unfolds a pamphlet for **ORCA FAMILY PLANNING & CLINIC.**

MONROE
You should've told me.

GILLY
Why? So you could offer me another opinion? I've already got one from my religion, my government, my friends… Why not *you*?

She picks up a PHOTO with her father, the Pastor, both forcing smiles outside the church.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Even with him frozen, I couldn't find the words to tell him.

MONROE
No, I just mean, they have these pills now-- my mom volunteers at a clinic. I could've helped--

GILLY
Oh, you've helped plenty.

Gilly glares at him, brushing dirt off her scarf.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Time didn't stop when I made the appointment. I was already at the bus stop… when I felt it… 'move'.

Her voice trembles. She sits on the bed, burying her head. Feeling the weight of her fear, Monroe joins her.

MONROE
What're you gonna do?

She traces her mom's handwriting on her POSTCARD, searching.

GILLY
All I know is every step outside this town feels like one step closer to her. So that's what I'll do.

MONROE
No.

The words slip out, surprising even Monroe himself. Gilly snaps up, eyes ablaze with hatred fuming.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I'm sorry, but whatever answer you're looking for, you won't find it in a postcard.

GILLY
Monroe. I don't need an 'answer.' I need an escape.

Gilly grabs her bag. Monroe seizes it too, stopping her.

MONROE
And I need honesty. I trusted you and you were gonna use me to, what? Rocket away from your problems.

GILLY
Oh my god, this isn't about you.

She yanks the backpack from his grip, marching away.

MONROE
No, but it is about us. You're not alone here anymore. If we're gonna spend the rest of eternity, you can't just-- where are you going??

GILLY
To spend eternity anywhere else.

Resolute, Gilly climbs back out the window. Monroe follows--

EXT. GILLY'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Monroe tumbles out after her, urgently trying to slow her.

MONROE
Wait-- Gilly wait. I-I wanted time to stop so badly. I couldn't decide which photo and my mom left and-- and it was all moving so fast… But I wanted it to happen and it did.

GILLY
Monroe, do you even hear yourself? Nobody goes 'Oopsie, my bad' and stops time simply by wanting it to--

MONROE
But you did. Didn't you?
(off her silence)
This world is our fault… We're the only ones who can fix it.

She swallows, the tears in her eyes betraying her truth.

GILLY
Fixing time… won't fix a world I can't fit into.

With assurance, Monroe speaks with passion and warmth.

MONROE
Of course you fit in that world. You flawlessly capture the soulful, untethered vocals of John Mayer, your pancakes taste like unicorn dreams. You pitch a mean curveball…
(off her smile, genuine)
And you're the best thing that's happened to me since time stopped.

Her smile fades as the bulldozer begins to free itself from the ditch, the KING LOGO tarp on it rising behind Monroe.

MONROE (CONT'D)
You're also the only thing that's happened to me. The first hint things can change. Until I figure out why -- you *can't just leave*. Don't you see?

Breath racing, Gilly notices how the KING LOGO now frames up behind Monroe like a sinister crown.

GILLY
Yeah, I see. You want to trap me here-- inside your tiny camera frame, next to a butterfly wing or a loose toenail. Another souvenir for your exhibit.

Gilly charges past him, heading for the woods. As Monroe hardens into something dark and bitter we've never seen.

MONROE
You're already trapped.
(dark beat)
Difference is -- you're doing it to yourself. No matter how far you get, you'll always wake up at that bus stop. No distance you run will separate you from your past.

Pulverized by pain, Gilly studies him, recognizing his grief.

GILLY
Why not? That's what you're doing.

A shiver threads down Monroe's back. She eyes his camera.

GILLY (CONT'D)
You have photos of every bird shit in town, every sidewalk crack, But NOTHING of the construction site. You won't pass it, won't get within a mile of it.

Gilly leans in… prodding for a reaction.

MONROE
That's not-- it's dangerous…

GILLY
How about we turn the camera lens on the skeletons in your closet?

She pounces, RIPPING THE CAMERA from his neck, and bolts out the window. Monroe pursues her with animalistic fury--

EXT. WOODS - MOMENTS LATER

Monroe sprints down the trail, gaining on Gilly.

MONROE
GILLY, STOP!

As she rounds a corner, Gilly kicks a FALLEN LOG, RESETTING LIKE A TRUCK ONTO MONROE, knocking him to the earth.

He grunts and wobbles back to his feet, but she's far ahead.

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

Out of breath, Monroe scans the horizon, glimpsing the stripe of RESETTING RAIN hurtling toward the construction site.

EXT. FINCHWOOD MONUMENT, CONSTRUCTION SITE - DAY

Six stories of rickety scaffolding zigzag into the clouds.

From here, the vague inklings of an UNFINISHED MONUMENT peek from behind an impenetrable GATE. A sign reads *CONSTRUCTION SUSPENDED -- NO TRESPASSING.* The structure juts into the lake on a peninsula, giving it the air of a fortress with a moat.

Gilly scales a nearby car, taunting Monroe with the camera.

MONROE
GIVE IT BACK--

He scales after her, but she jumps onto another car. Monroe chases her along the traffic. But she's too nimble--

GILLY
Let's take a look at the evidence--
(looking through images)
Boats, boats, more boats. What's up with you and boats?

She jumps down, and tries to scramble up the site's giant gate, but slides down its slick surface. Monroe catches up.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Are you an arsonist? Serial killer?

She clocks a HEAVY PADLOCK on the fence, military-grade. She grabs a brick and strikes it, but it hardly cracks.

MONROE
You can't open this. Just stop!

She climbs a truck, toggling the camera's ZOOM over the fence.

(CONTINUED)

GILLY
Fine. Then a photo will do.

The CAMERA POV narrows in on the wisp of smoke, its source obscured from this low angle.

MONROE
GILLY -- STOP!

SNAP -- a Polaroid floats to his feet. Monroe lunges for the image -- slashes it apart -- but it keeps reforming.

GILLY
Another angle perhaps? Closer?

SNAP -- Another falls in his face. Forcing him to look.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Still not clear enough for you?

SNAP -- Monroe covers his eyes. Desperate.

MONROE
PLEASE make this stop!!

Scanning the street, he sees a WATER HOSE on a FIRE TRUCK.

GILLY
Let's make this one count--

And she aims it the lens -- right as -- PSSSHHHHH!!

The WATER blasts Gilly like a typhoon, SLAPPING her to the concrete. She coughs, winded… as the hose slurps back in its liquid, leaving her perfectly dry again.

The blast launches his CAMERA over the edge. Collateral.

Monroe hovers above her, aiming the nozzle like a pistol. But Gilly just looks up at him, perfectly calm.

GILLY (CONT'D)
You're wrong. This world isn't our fault. It's a blessing. Cause it might restart at any moment, any moment you could lose this all, and you'll look back and wonder why you *tortured* yourself waiting for permission to be happy. I wish you could see that… Then maybe choosing one stupid photo wouldn't be so hard.

Disturbed, Monroe claws at his neck, scanning the pavement--

MONROE
Where is it?! My camera? WHY ISN'T IT RESETTING?

EXT. WATER UNDER FINCHWOOD MONUMENT - MOMENTS LATER

Like the stuff he threw before, his camera impaled the lake so far downward, that it has become trapped beneath.

Monroe claws at the jello-like surface, but his precious camera JIGGLES beyond his reach.

GILLY
I'm sorry, I didn't mean to…

Monroe releases an earth-shattering SCREAM. Gilly presses her eyes shut as it echoes across the landscape. Followed by the scathing silence.

MONROE
(whisper)
You deserve to rot here with your baby.

A flash of horror across Gilly as she, in turn, hardens.

GILLY
I should've let you jump.

She fades into the rain. The droplets spring off her skin as if she were a boiling hotplate.

Off Monroe, a kaleidoscope of sorrow.

INT. MONROE'S HOUSE, VARIOUS - DAY

PAINTINGS and PHOTOS adorn every wall. Failed ARCHITECTURAL MODELS and BLUEPRINTS clutter Grant's messy study.

BOTTLE of PILLS vie for space beside PAINT TUBES in Aurora's studio. A trash overflows with TISSUES in the corner.

A stack of FELLOWSHIP REJECTION LETTERS (Getty, Nat Geo among them) would gather dust if this world had any.

A home frozen in cramped chaos, struggling to swallow its darkness beneath a mask of routine.

Monroe stands before a wall of ANIMAL PAINTINGS -- a frog, a gator, a bat, a starling, a flock of gulls… Monochromatic with a splash of a unique color. But not one of them is finished.

A **WHITE GAP** invades each frame, like a deranged ADHD museum.

He focuses on a PORTRAIT OF HIM. A **WHITE GAP** blurs into his face, rendering it forever UNFINISHED. He traces the negative space, disturbed by how it forms a white car.

THUMP. He RIPS the painting down. Then another. Another. One by one, the house sheds its colors into a shell of white.

(CONTINUED)

GRANT'S STUDY - MOMENTS LATER

Chest heaving, Monroe hurls the paintings inside a closet in Grant's study and slams the door. The door BULGES as the swarm of trapped canvases tries to escape like caged birds.

Back pressed to the door, his anxiety calms. His stepdad's yellow SAFETY VEST drapes a chair. Left behind that day.

Monroe frowns at the vest, its presence here unsettling him.

INT. GRANT'S BUS - DAY

Monroe sidles down the aisle, scanning gruff and weary CONSTRUCTION WORKERS. He freezes, eyes widening as he spots--

GRANT, in an ill-fitting business suit and tie, gripping a BRIEFCASE in his calloused hands. Exhaustion chiseled in the bags under his eyes, head tilting downwards as if asleep.

MONROE
Oh, right. Big meeting today.
Almost didn't recognize you.

Unsure and shy, Monroe takes a seat beside him, clutching a REJECTION LETTER from the prestigious GETTY FELLOWSHIP.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Finally got my fellowship schedule set. What do ya think?
(shows him the page)
Yeah, I know. The 8 am workshop was a tad ambitious, but they paired me with an incredible mentor who does these crazy chiaroscuro blends.

He frowns at the GIANT CO BADGE peeking out from Grant's pocket.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I know you were looking forward to me working with you next year…

Monroe rummages past REJECTED BLUEPRINTS and PROPOSALS.

MONROE (CONT'D)
But that stipend money was too hard to turn down, right?

Trembling, Monroe opens a flyer for the FINCHWOOD ART FAIR.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Where were you? Why didn't you stop her? WHY?! GAAAAAAAAAAHHH!

He rises to SCREAMS IN GRANT'S FACE. Once he's emptied his lungs, he slumps back down beside him, and sobs--

MONROE (CONT'D)
Why aren't you here right now… Why aren't you ever here…

--Leaning his head against his frozen father's shoulder.

EXT. CHURCH - DAY

Gilly faces her father. Her lips part to say something… Then close. She can't do it.

Instead, she takes out a NAIL POLISH from Miranda's purse, bathing it in color. She walks to her father… PASSING HIM--

Approaching the WHITE STAINED GLASS window behind him with a **KING LOGO** in its corner.

And there it is again. The glorious **PINK** stroke. She smiles and keeps going. Painting SOMETHING we do not see… Then--

She crumples to the tile, rubbing the dried **YELLOW** on her shoes. She RUBS and RUBS it, but it won't come off.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DREAM SEQUENCE

This moment again. The frames now shiver forward in stiff, jagged slow-mo. Painfully inching toward SOMETHING BURIED.

Monroe, wide-eyed, faces the silhouette of a foreboding MAN inside the WHITE PONTIAC as it passes, slowing as it nears--

--then accelerating away in a threatening beat.

POP! Before he can grasp what's happening, he turns to see the balloons from Aurora's boat dancing free -- POP!

Another bursts. POP! POP! POP! One by one, all the balloons erupt like slow-mo mini fireworks.

*Until there's just one left -- one **PINK** BALLOON. Floating beyond his reach of the rail. POP! POP! POP! The sound keeps going like a metronome, but nothing is popping.*

Off Monroe's fear, trying to understand that last balloon---

EXT. MARINA - DAY

Monroe sleeps, tangled within a rat's nest of rigging on the back of the yacht. Candy wrappers and beer bottles swaddle him in a suffocating cocoon.

His foot pops up… then his leg floats… His waist…

Like guitar strings, one by one the ropes stretch and SNAP, as the resetting force wrenches his limp body up, up, up--

EXT. LAKE - DAY

--Dragging him across the lake by his foot… His HEAD smacks the backside of a frozen wave, waking him with a start!

Flailing, he falls flat on his back, the force dropping him like a sack of flour. He moans…

He lies there in a depressive haze, scowling at the clouds.

Without moving, the resetting force begins tugging again, like a puppy dog chewing his leg. As he drags--

MONROE
Ugh, let me go… Let me go…

EXT. CANALS - DAY

Monroe slugs past Fred. He makes a square 'finger-frame' pretending to hold a camera at him--

MONROE
Snap… Snap…

EXT. UNDER THE CANAL BRIDGE - DAY

Monroe passes the staircase leading to Nolan's camp. He pauses, contemplating the short walk down to his friend.

But instead, just keeps walking past him.

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

A BLANKET has been draped over the **WHITE GAP**, but it resets horizontally, making it look like a ghost in a wind tunnel.

As Monroe passes it, his momentum slows, its gravitational force pulling him in. He heaves forward as if suddenly gaining weight, then speeds back up as he gains distance.

EXT. FINCHWOOD MONUMENT, CONSTRUCTION SITE - DAY

Monroe places a hand on the gate, his wrist now checkered with SEVERAL MORE **RED** CUTS in various states of healing.

INT. COMMUNITY CENTER, GALLERY - DAY

Monroe sifts through slightly different versions of old photos: Bird. Lighthouse. Boat. Bird. Lighthouse. Boat. Bird.

Uninspired, he drops the photos, picking up the neglected CONSTRUCTION INTERNSHIP BROCHURE instead.

On top, Grant's "backup plan" sticky note beckons to him like a white flag of surrender.

EXT. PLAYGROUND - DAY

Disheveled and drunk, Monroe sips beer, rocking on the swing set. Each arc resets to the same height, a perfect pendulum.

Monroe peruses the brochure mindlessly. Bootcamps. Workshops. Grant has even included a coupon for a local tailor. Yawn.

He hiccups, then sifts through a pile of Grant's REJECTED PROJECTS, searching for some hint of excitement. But each design blurs into the next: A bridge. A courtyard. A library--

A **'NOTICE OF COURT HEARING'?** Addressed to GRANT. Monroe stares at it, his boozed-out neurons struggling to fire.

A loud SNORE from the heavens breaks his trance…

A pinkish **blob** streaks across the sky like a drunken shooting star -- GILLY'S SLEEPING BODY floats back from somewhere.

Monroe chuckles… He rises and roams off like a zombie.

EXT. LAKE, WAVE CREST - LATER

Monroe scales the wave. A stone-faced Gilly gazes out at the horizon, a suitcase beside her.

MONROE
Get up. My turn.

Cruel and sterile. Their playful innocence long gone.

GILLY
I get morning. You get night.

MONROE
Well, it's nighttime now.

GILLY
(points at daytime sky)
You can't just decide that.

Monroe unfolds his BIRTHDAY HAT and puts it on.

(CONTINUED)

MONROE
But it’s my birthday.

GILLY
It was your birthday yesterday.

MONROE
Aren’t you supposed to be in Fiji by now? How’s that suntan coming?

GILLY
Great, how’s that kitten fart you call a beard coming?

He’s about to start with her when she turns fully toward him, absorbing her disheveled hair and red eyes… He sits instead.

MONROE
How far did you get this time?

GILLY
Doesn’t matter.

Monroe sniffs the air. Gilly zips her suitcase tighter, as he glimpses a label -- TURPENTINE. A shiver races down his spine.

The two gaze at the foggy horizon in heavy silence. Gilly finally breaks it, her voice a shy whisper.

GILLY (CONT’D)
If time moves forward... how do you even know your mom will come back?

Monroe inhales sharply, but his words tremble with resolve.

MONROE
It’s called hope.

Gilly studies the King’s abandoned CONSTRUCTION SITE.

GILLY
What a waste.

MONROE
My mom made a promise. She never broke a promise.

GILLY
What if you’re wrong?

MONROE
You couldn’t possibly understand a mother’s love.

Gilly withers at the cruel remark. She nods and rises.

GILLY
You're right… But I think I am starting to understand "forever."

She eyes the CONSTRUCTION INTERNSHIP BROCHURE on his lap, clocking his similar hopeless state.

GILLY (CONT'D)
And it looks like you are too.

With that, she brushes past, leaving Monroe to reluctantly sift through the brochure.

INT. MONROE'S HOUSE, STUDY - DAY

Monroe slips on his father's YELLOW VEST, its pensive weight sinking over his shoulders as he accepts his future.

EXT. "KING'S GARDEN", COURTYARD - DAY

The omnipresent STATUE OF KING peers down at Monroe as he enters the courtyard, rolling a mini CEMENT MIXER.

Feigning excitement, he swaggers past King, wearing the yellow vest and tool belt. He tilts his HARD HAT in greeting.

MONROE
Howdy boss, reporting for duty.

Swallowing his nerves, he pushes into the--

EXT. "KING'S GARDEN", HEDGE MAZE - CONTINUOUS

--Weaving through the Byzantine labyrinth of overgrown bushes. They twist around Monroe like spectral snakes.

MONROE
Watch out, everyone! Construction coming through.

Playful features inhabit the maze. A stone cherub smiles mischievously. A merry birdbath trickles. A watchful owl peeks out from inside a divot.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Check out my callouses. I'm just like my pops. God, I love…
(checks mixer)
Cement and Porto-potties.

Monroe shouts to the heavens as if someone could hear him.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Yep. Ready to move forward, world.
Embrace my destiny. Woooo!

At a dead end, the unruly hedges entrap a weathered BENCH. He looks around, lost, then steps on it to peek over the wall.

CRACK! The bench SNAPS, and Monroe TUMBLES FORWARD -- THROUGH THE HEDGE MAZE--

DEEPER IN THE HEDGE MAZE

--Landing face first on the other side… Moaning, he stays on the ground a beat, the world spinning around him.

Light struggles to penetrate the foliage here, washing him in a sickly green as his bloodshot eyes refocus.

A **YELLOW FOOTPRINT** blossoms into view. A trail of them. The same shade from the bottom of Gilly's shoes.

Monroe rises and begins to follow the spattering of golden tracks as they snake around a corner.

Left. Right. Left… He weaves through the maze. Until…

EXT. "KING'S GARDEN", ABANDONED PAVILION - CONTINUOUS

The hedges open up into a forgotten pavilion. Trash litters a chipped platform, surrounded by the green walls.

In the center, a decaying GAZEBO. Monroe wanders in. His toe knocks an overturned CAN OF **YELLOW** PAINT. The prints stem from this puddle like a sun ray, beside an EMPTY PEDESTAL.

A stage for a model to pose. This place was once a private atelier, an intimate space for an artist and subject to meet.

MONROE
Whoa cool!

Under a sagging awning, a brick kiln slumps, mired with moss. Dusty shelves and work benches host chisels and carving tools.

All bear the unmistakable mark of their sculptor — KING's LOGO adorns every surface, from drop cloths to each tiny brush.

MONROE (CONT'D)
(to the sky)
Alright. I see what you want me to do. I can do this. Yeah…

Working himself up, Monroe spots a loose board on the GAZEBO. He swaggers over to it with a HAMMER and NAIL.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Look at me go! This is my life now.

BANG BANG! He hammers haphazardly -- the nail tries to inch back up the wood, but as long as Monroe works quickly, the friction seems to catch. He wipes sweat, laughing.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I'm doing it! I'm doing it!

Suddenly, the plank SPLINTERS -- spitting the nail out like a cannon. Monroe ducks as it ROCKETS into the awning. The wood caves in, cracking open the kiln below with a massive THUD.

Monroe coughs as dust and debris fill the air. Among the mess, SCULPTED FEMALE BODY PARTS also zoom out from the tomb, resetting along the shelves like little soldiers.

Monroe approaches, unsettled by the arms, legs, and torsos flying around… A serial killer or an artist? Hard to tell…

He picks up a FRAMED NEWSPAPER CLIPPING. It reads "**KING CONSTRUCTION'S SPARROW'S GARDEN REVAMP FACES LOCAL PUSHBACK.**"

The photo features a fiery GILLY speaking in a TOWN HALL. She waves a PROTEST SIGN with the slogan *"Green, not grey!"*

GILLY (O.S.)
What are you doing here?

Monroe snaps around to find Gilly, gripping an AEROSOL CAN.

GILLY (CONT'D)
You need to leave this place. Now.

But Monroe focuses on a LARGE STATUE, veiled under a blanket in a corner, previously hidden behind the kiln.

Drawn to it, he reaches for the shroud. Gilly tries to intersect him, but he's closer and yanks it back, revealing--

THE MISSING QUEEN STATUE -- GILLY.

Lifelike, it captures her awkward beauty with staggering precision, every freckle and curl magnified.

GILLY (CONT'D)
I made a promise too, Monroe.

Gilly feels the rip in her scarf, lost in a memory.

GILLY (CONT'D)
He promised he would stop the
garden remodel if I helped him…
with a project of his own.

Monroe studies the framed newspaper photo, realizing--

MONROE
King was… in love with you.

GILLY
King was in love with his *version* of me.

She CRACKS the frame open -- a stream of ALARMING IMAGES slip out. Monroe shudders at odd closeups of her body… a lock of hair… disturbing drawings of Gilly posing for her sculptor…

With an icy gaze, Gilly faces her ever-smiling face pulverized in the haunted statue.

GILLY (CONT'D)
He told me sculptors 'see' the model inside the rock before they touch the stone -- that he just frees it… But I never felt free.
(holding back tears)
Not when he touched me. Not when he lied to me or razed her garden. And certainly not when he posed me on that stage and proceeded to chisel me… over and over again into the shape he most desired.

Her hand falls to her belly.

ON MONROE, processing the horror.

MONROE
Gilly, you need to tell someone, the police or--

GILLY
They'll protect him--

MONROE
Your father! A friend--

GILLY
NO ONE can ever find out!

She plants herself firmly, hands clenched in anger. Monroe's eyes drift to her BUMP, filled with empathy.

MONROE
He doesn't know.

GILLY
And never will.

Suddenly, he sniffs the air -- above, a claw of YELLOW LIQUID scrapes the sky.

Gilly watches it with a vengeful glint, as a panicked Monroe starts running back through the maze…

EXT. "KING'S GARDEN", COURTYARD - MOMENTS LATER

Monroe bursts into the courtyard, Gilly in tow.

Canisters of TURPENTINE lace King's statue like ornaments, fixed with a complex wire braid that extends into a makeshift fuse. Weightless, it wags like King's tail, spilling yellow.

GILLY
Pygmalion's love brought a statue to life. But no one ever checked to be sure… Cause if they'd peeled back her flesh and clay, it wasn't love they'd find… But a queen, waiting for her turn to hold the chisel.

MONROE
Stop! You'll destroy the whole town!

Brandishing a lit votive candle, she raises the aerosol can.

Its frozen flame spasms as she presses the nozzle, aiming its inferno at the tail-end of the canister fuse.

GILLY
No. I'm "freeing" it.

SHHH -- a violent ribbon of RED and ORANGE ripples toward the statue -- ***KABOOM!!!***

The statue fractures and blazes with a hellish glow. King's crown twinkles atop it like demonic horns. Splashes of blue sizzle and pop as the turpentine violently ignites.

But the explosion REVERSES like a black hole! As it *SLLLUUUUURPS* back its fireball of debris--

--striking a GOLF CAR -- which rolls into a row of TRASH CANS -- which fall domino style onto a BARBECUE, reaching a PROPANE TANK. The gas leaks, nearing the FLAME… and--

BOOM! BOOM! Unleashing a **resetting Rube-Goldberg machine**.

MONROE
…Oh Gilly, what have you done?

LAWN MOWERS and BASKETBALL HOOPS and PARK BENCHES swirl, the chaotic motion becoming impossible to track as it spreads.

Monroe yanks Gilly out of the way of the inferno--

MONROE (CONT'D)
We need to get out of here!

But the flames shrivel. Her flare resets. The canisters quiver and jingle… as the STATUE REFORMS.

GILLY SCREAMS and rips herself from Monroe's embrace. She grabs a crowbar and charges at the statue!

GILLY
HE'S ALWAYS THERE! WHY IS HE ALWAYS THERE?!

MONROE
Gilly, stop! It's useless!

The HEDGE MAZE ignites, slithering like a satanic snake as the flame spreads deeper into the STREETS AND TOWN!

The feedback loop expands. FLYING TIRES, SPURTING FIRE HYDRANTS, and RUNAWAY TRUCKS zip past -- the statue stands tall at the gale's swelling center. *The eye of a hurricane.*

And as the chaos spreads, so do the **COLORS**, painting the sky like a psychedelic aurora borealis.

Monroe swerves as the ROOSTER STATUE nearly sides-swipes him.

SLAM. SLAM. SLAM. Gilly continues SMASHING.

King's face fractures. Dust gushes the air. Faster. FASTER--

GILLY
LET ME LEAVE! LET ME LEAVE!

Like a hive of angry hornets, razor shards of stone swarm… SLICING into Gilly's fists. **BLOOD** fuses with debris.

MONROE
You're hurting yourself, stop--

Gilly shoves Monroe off and continues to pound.

Seeing no other option, Monroe lifts a sheet of metal and -- ***WAM*** -- intercepts Gilly's blow, holding her back.

GILLY
WHY ARE YOU PROTECTING HIM? HE'S WHY I'M HERE! TRAPPED IN THIS TOWN--

MONROE
We're not trapped in this town.
We're trapped IN TIME--

GILLY
What's the DIFFERENCE?!

MONROE
We can still live in this town. But not in a world where nothing we 'do' matters!

With no obstacles, King's statue rebuilds, its cracks heal, and the stone gleams anew as if never touched.

Gilly just melts, hallowed and depleted.

GILLY
I hate to break it to you, but that's the world I already live in.

The vortex of RESETTING DEBRIS rips a YACHT from the lake and hurls it between them!

Monroe dodges, but when the boat passes, Gilly is gone.

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

On the horizon, the vortex swells, gobbling boats, street lamps, trucks… Growing darker and *hungrier*.

Monroe spots Gilly, undeterred as marches through the haze.

EXT. BUS STOP - DAY

Trees shiver in the resetting gale. A shopping cart rolls down a hill, then back up it like a glitched-out tumbleweed.

The FROZEN COMMUTERS have blown away, nowhere to be seen. But Monroe hardly notices, desperate to reach--

The bench. Gilly sits in her spot. Her harrowing gaze focused ahead… An INVISIBLE COATING has begun to sheath over her.

MONROE
Gilly, you have to keep moving.

GILLY
But I'm so tired of… moving.

He yanks her STIFF arm. She won't budge. Her breathing slows.

GILLY (CONT'D)
You were right, Monroe… I'll never outrun him…

MONROE
Gilly?! No, Gilly! Don't give up!

Monroe heaves against her FROZEN BODY, checking his entire weight against hers like a football player.

MONROE (CONT'D)
You have to keep… moving…

…slowly her hips peel from the bench like superglue…

Monroe presses harder -- the INVISIBLE COATING splinters like fresh snow. Catapulting the two of them to the pavement. A marvel of raindrops whirls above their heads.

The two just lie there, breathing in sync and in silence.

Gilly starts to sob. Monroe gives her the space to just be.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I'm sorry, Gilly. I really am.

Gilly sits up, absorbing the town's hazy beauty.

GILLY
I actually used to love this town. He took that from me. And now it's gone forever.

MONROE
No, not forever.

Monroe spins the "GILLY" pin on her backpack.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I don't think time moves in a straight line -- it squeezes and stretches. Stops and starts. The only endless loops are the ones we make in our minds -- the ones we time-travel to over and over. But it's not forever. Not when you realize you can also move <u>forward</u>. But that starts with telling the truth, instead of running from it.

Gilly unclips the pin, wading through a memory.

GILLY
When I was born, they told me I was a 'gift.'... When my mom bled out like a piñata on the operating table, when they RIPPED me from her gut, they told me <u>I was a GIFT</u>.
(beat)
If he ever finds out… is that all I'll be? Flesh-colored wrapping paper for his legacy of pain?

Monroe studies King's LOGO on an unfinished building nearby.

MONROE
King left. He's a coward. That's his legacy. And if you stay silent, you'll rot from inside. Just like this town.
(solemn beat)
Maybe that's what you want. God knows you have every right to want to burn this place to the ground… But if it's not, if you still think there's some hope left to squeeze out of these sidewalk cracks… don't let him make that decision for you.

GILLY
I'm scared, Monroe. As long as I'm in Stillness, I don't need to make decisions. As long as I'm here, I CAN'T make the wrong decision…
(voice quivering)
Cause if I did, I wouldn't know how to fill the hole left in my heart.

Monroe's eyes flicker with understanding. He unsheathes the SILVER PAINTBRUSH and offers it to her.

MONROE
With color.

Gilly takes it, blossoming from her cocoon again--

But it's short-lived. A shrill GROAN as the cyclone yanks the BRIDGE off its foundation -- slinging it into the KING'S LOGO. White walls erupt, joining the *spiraling chaos*.

MONROE (CONT'D)
RUN!

As the bridge tries to reset, it scrapes against the street, scooping up BUILDINGS and CARS as it travels, chasing after them like the boulder from *Indiana Jones*.

Monroe leads Gilly down a SIDE STREET -- the bridge passes.

They gasp at the expanding sphere of destruction-- buildings trying to reset, smashing into more buildings… On and on…

Off the two, watching their frozen world begin to stir--

EXT. INDUSTRIAL PLANT - DAY

Monroe and Gilly rush up along the belt to the silo-- *SMASH!* A TRANSMISSION PYLON skewers the hatch. Gilly saves Monroe before the metal strut shish-kabobs him.

PHOTOS spray out like a geyser. Monroe saves as many as he can, including his SUPER 8 FILM REEL.

GILLY
We need to find another place!

MONROE
(hesitates, then)
This way--

INT. MONROE'S HOUSE, FOYER/STUDY - DAY

Monroe and Gilly shove a PICNIC BENCH through the threshold. It resets against the door like a barricade.

Outside, the storm rages -- a FREIGHT TRAIN CAR flies by.

GILLY
Yeah… that's not gonna last.

Monroe makes a beeline for the kitchen, where he stuffs a pile of FELLOWSHIP REJECTION LETTERS behind a couch.

GILLY (CONT'D)
It's going to flatten the entire town. We have to stop that thing!

MONROE
We can't -- it's a feedback loop. Any change might make it worse!

GILLY
Worse than us becoming as flat as Jenkins' pancakes??

MONROE
I know-- I know! FUCK. How'd we manage to fuck up time so badly?

Resigned, Monroe buries his face. But Gilly digs in, not accepting this, fingers uncurling in determination.

GILLY
But we un-fuck it, right? You said we could fix it. How do we fix it?

MONROE
I've tried everything! Every photo. Every time-related trope. Even a note to the future!

GILLY
Maybe there's a big button somewhere. There's always a big button--

She paces past Grant's STUDY, double-taking at a MODEL inside.

Awestruck, she enters, unfolding her pamphlet for **ORCA FAMILY PLANNING** -- its name matches the model's.

GILLY (CONT'D)
I thought the nearest one was like 200 miles away?

MONROE
It was. My stepdad wanted to build one closer. Among all his other projects that never panned out…

Monroe nods to a shelf, where more unrealized Giant Co ARCHITECTURAL MODELS gather dust. Gilly smiles at the clinic.

GILLY
Well I, for one, would love to see one closer to that church…

EEEK. Gilly's attention shifts to the bulging CLOSET DOOR, groaning with Aurora's resetting paintings locked inside.

GILLY (CONT'D)
What's in here?

MONROE
Wait, don't open that---

Too late! As she swings open the door, the CANVASES take flight -- soaring through the house before gently settling against the walls like liberated birds finding their perches.

Gilly walks past the eerie UNFINISHED PAINTINGS. She traces a **WHITE GAP** etched into the abdomen of a FROG.

GILLY
Whoa. It's like she carved out a place for it before the brush touched the canvas.

MONROE
More like it carved out a place in her. You'd never know it by looking at her. So happy and upbeat. But on the canvas, this storm brewed. She'd always reach the same spot and just… stop.

Monroe squirms under the disturbing gaze of Aurora's PORTRAIT OF HIMSELF, the odd CAR-SHAPED **WHITE GAP** shadowing his face.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Can we put these away now…

Gilly joins him in front of the PORTRAIT, suddenly blanching.

GILLY
Monroe… Did your mom have a thing for white Pontiac Fieros?

MONROE
What, no? Why?

GILLY
(pointing at **WHITE GAP**)
Cause that's King's car.

Monroe studies it, recognizing the PONTIAC from his dream.

MONROE
Wait, I saw that car. I saw it the day time stopped.

Fear washes over both their faces as they realize…

GILLY
He's-he's back? But why?

They hurry to the PERMITS on Grant's desk. A circle on a map indicates the clinic's intended building site—-

King's old CONSTRUCTION SITE. Monroe's heart skips a beat.

MONROE
Grant finally convinced the city.

GILLY
That would definitely piss King off.

A troubled thought strikes Monroe. He uncrumples the **NOTICE OF COURT HEARING** he found in Grant's drawings.

MONROE
Enough to take him to court?

GILLY
Yeah maybe. King was obsessive. He built statues as a way to bribe politicians, judges, parking attendants… Anyone. If your stepdad has something King wants, he's in for an unfair fight.

Reignited, Monroe upends a STACK OF CANVASES from the closet, flipping through them -- Gilly ducks as they swarm the air.

GILLY (CONT'D)
What're you doing?!

MONROE
There's gotta be more messages! My stepdad decides to wear a suit for the first time in twenty years, King returns, and time just stops?

GILLY
…What are the chances…

The images settle on a wall behind him as Gilly's jaw drops.

MONROE
Exactly! Like what are the chances--

GILLY
No, Monroe… What are the chances--

He follows her astonished gaze to the STARLING PAINTING…

…Which upon closer inspection consists of HUNDREDS OF STARLINGS. The bird made of birds. Gliding over the lake. Between sunbeams. It's the same view as the wave.

GILLY (CONT'D)
--Your mom's been here before?

Gilly turns Monroe to face all the other PAINTINGS:

- The BAT? No, that's Nolan's BATMAN TATTOO.

- The FROG? That's Hazel's stuffed animal.

- The GULLS soar past the LIGHTHOUSE -- clock frozen at 10:16.

All the little moments of Stillness. Hidden in animal imagery. Captured in incomplete but unmistakable details.

CRASH!! A window bursts open -- glass and brick flood the tiny space like a snow globe. A KNIFE SET narrowly avoids Monroe's throat. A CEILING FAN bounces off a wall near Gilly.

They dive beneath a bed, right as-- the ROOF RIPS off!

A sickly pale surges over Monroe as he watches the vile TWISTER shred Aurora's PAINTINGS like rainbow confetti.

His FILM FOOTAGE swooshes by -- the silvery frame of his FIVE-YEAR-OLD SELF popping a balloon lands upon a PAINTING OF A PINK BALLOON, overlaying the two images for a brief moment.

Monroe sees this, absorbing the connection. He RUSHES out--

GILLY (CONT'D)
Monroe -- no, leave it!

But he won't! The painting gets jammed behind the washing machine. As he tugs, Gilly emerges from her shelter to help.

They free it -- just as Gilly looks up and screams!

As the **FREAKIN' LIGHTHOUSE SWINGS THROUGH THE HOUSE** like a battering ram!

EXT. MONROE'S HOUSE - MOMENTS LATER

The storm moves on, leaving a hollowed crater. They crawl out from under the bed, watching the vortex churn up the canals.

GILLY
You okay?

Monroe wipes happy tears -- *more than okay*. He holds up the painting: a solitary **PINK** BALLOON ascending above a vortex.

Its title - **"The Pink Promise."**

GILLY (CONT'D)
What does it mean?

MONROE
Every year, I'd pop these balloons like candles. It was this game I played with my mom as a kid, but it was her way of teaching me it was okay to grow up, move on… We pop this balloon, time moves forward.

Gilly furrows her brow, confused at the simplicity.

GILLY
Popping a balloon? Really?

MONROE
Not just any balloon. This balloon.

GILLY
But… what if it was just a game?

Monroe's urgency grows palpable, eyes widening in a mixture of desperation and determination.

MONROE
What if this whole WORLD is a game, Gilly? Everything we do here doesn't matter. And all these dreams I keep having… Her paintings… They're all pointing to this -- this is how we fix time!

Still unsure, but moved by his fervor, she nods.

GILLY
Okay yeah. Beats blender town…
What's next?

MONROE
C'mon. I bet we can find it. Just need a place with a clear view.

Gilly sighs at the disaster zone of LIGHTHOUSE debris.

GILLY
Well, there goes our lighthouse…

A glint catches her eye -- she plucks a floating TELESCOPE from beneath a disjointed rafter. Monroe grins.

The two trade determined looks and run toward town. The raindrops billowing in ripples behind them.

EXT. CANALS - DAY

An apocalyptic war zone of time-bending destruction. Displaced jelly water flows up and down, trying to return.

But the canals have been so mutilated they flow in perpetual loops… resembling an Escher waterfall painting.

Gilly trains her telescope to the sky, scanning for any shade of pink in the marshmallowy mush of sky. Nothing.

MONROE
We need to get higher -- this way!

They dart through the courtyard. Climbing, climbing…

FIRE ESCAPE

As they ascend, the **iridescent** TORNADO of resetting junk blossoms like a tie-dye sunrise.

Beautiful and horrifying, it howls on the horizon like a grizzly bear.

ROOFTOP

High above the canals, between tightly-packed houses.

The corridor abruptly ends and Monroe nearly stumbles off. Gilly yanks him back and points to a spot on the horizon.

GILLY
Monroe!! Look!

She tosses him the scope. He focuses the POV on--

A PINK **BALLOON**, floating high on the town's edge. Monroe hoists his mom's painting -- it aligns perfectly.

MONROE
That's it! That's the one.

A RRRRUMBLE from below -- a river of debris churns by in the canal, flooding so high it reaches the rooftop. *RRRUUMMMBLE!*

Upstream, the CHURCH STEEPLE clips off, striking the WATER TOWER. It spills liquid into a massive, amoeba TIDAL WAVE, careening straight for the rooftop!

Monroe spots a FISHING BOAT swelling to their height in the canal. He extends a hand to Gilly.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Still want to go surfing?

With a running leap, they SCREAM and land on the BOAT--

EXT. FISHING BOAT (MOVING), CANALS - CONTINUOUS

They surf along the resetting current of debris, ricocheting off walls. Each impact spits up eddies of flotsam.

But unlike the bulldozer, this isn't fun. As their vessel takes damage, it fractures under their fingertips. Monroe and Gilly hold on for dear life, shifting closer.

Their surface area shrinks-- shrinks-- until it's just a hunk of driftwood… a single plank… then GONE!

Suddenly they're falling, caught in a stream of SHEER STUFF.

Weightlessness. A moment of ZERO-G… Right as--

WOOOSH!

The current hawks them out violently onto the LAKE--

EXT. LAKE - CONTINUOUS

--Where they bounce to a stop along the soft, gushy waves.

MONROE
Well, that was…

Gilly's eyes are saucers, hair blown out like a lion's man.

GILLY
Overrated.

Capsized boats and jet skis mar the lake's surface like icebergs. A surreal wasteland at the border of a canvas.

Behind them, barely any town remains. But ahead, the **CONSTRUCTION SITE** looms, tall and foreboding across the lake. The only structure untouched from the Vortex… Yet.

And above it -- the **PINK** BALLOON bobs like a beacon, anchored on something. Monroe pales as he realizes where he must go.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Are you sure about this?

Determined, Monroe takes off along the shore. Gilly follows.

EXT. FINCHWOOD MONUMENT, CONSTRUCTION SITE - DAY

They race up to the military-grade PADLOCK on the fence.

Trying to hide his shaking hands, Monroe takes out a weathered key. Gilly helps him insert it.

CACLUNK. With an agonizing ache, the giant gate croaks open--

The monument resembles the BUST of a MAN: a doorway at the man's torso. A lookout atop his head facing the water. Monroe and Gilly approach -- tiny ants in comparison.

A row of cars have been parked for an EVENT being set up that day -- King's WHITE PONTIAC glistens by a stage. Pristine. Across the lake, the VORTEX creeps closer.

They pass shiny, new EXCAVATORS slumbering beneath tarps.

UP THE STAIRS

The planks shiver as they thunder up. But the stairs suddenly stop at an incomplete bridge.

The long neck of a MOBILE CRANE arches nearby.

Monroe kicks a stack of LEAD PIPES. They roll off the side and SLAM into the CRANE -- it SPINS around like a top, and as it rotates back, the added momentum closes the gap to them.

They hop aboard and tread--

UP THE CRANE

Along its neck. They jump onto the next story -- a tangle of NARROW GIRDERS and SCAFFOLDING.

SCAFFOLDING

The **PINK** BALLOON blinks brighter. A North Star in the grey.

GRRRR… The Monument strains as the VORTEX approaches -- golden hues swirl by as BUCKETS OF PAINT spill their content.

They weave through the iron jungle gym. But the higher they get, the more scarce the scaffolding -- *CCCRACKKK!*

Monroe falters as a weathered section of catwalk snaps off, swallowed up by the ravenous gale. A dead end.

GILLY
We need another way! Let's go down.

But Monroe ignores her, focused on a CRANE LOAD level to their height. He jumps on. Gilly nervously follows him onto--

THE CRANE LOAD

A TOWER CRANE lifts slabs of concrete, so high it vanishes in the dark clouds. Monroe scans for the **PINK** with wild eyes.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Monroe, slow down! Maybe we should--

He snatches a nearby paint bucket and DUMPS it onto the load's QUICK RELEASE.

The RED LEVER drops the slabs and they ROCKET UP--

INTO THE VORTEX

All around them, debris churns in a putrid **rainbow**, draining DOWNWARD like a water spout… The horizon blurred.

They grab onto the crane's metal ribs and pull themselves up.

Monroe spots a **PINK** SPEC, high above them.

MONROE
It's still too high.

He teeters out onto the crane, waving at her.

Gilly sticks closer to the OPERATOR ROOM, nervous. She snaps off the circular end of a joystick, holding it like a ball.

She grips her telescope, idea cementing.

GILLY
MONROE!
(she tosses SCOPE to him)
How's your curveball?

He nods. Preps his swing, wielding the scope like a bat.

She winds up a PITCH and LET'S IT FLY!

SLAM! Monroe hits it right on the money!

The scope SPLITS IN HALF. Tumbles into the storm.

As the ball strikes the **PINK** target through the clouds--

POP!

And then…

Nothing. It just reforms.

Monroe starts to laugh. Slowly at first, then maniacal and crazed. Inhuman almost.

GILLY (CONT'D)
What is it?

Laughing still, Monroe snaps off a metal beam--

MONROE
You know, I never got into any fellowship. I got rejected from every single program.

--Fishing down the balloon string. It reads **CONGRATULATIONS!**

MONROE (CONT'D)
But my mom said there was hope… always hope.

He cradles the **PINK** BALLOON, pressing firmly on its latex.

MONROE (CONT'D)
She insisted I do this art fair, promised she'd help… She was so happy that day. Painting. Always painting. But when I needed her most, she vanished…

The balloon POPS under his grip.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I did see her boat though… rocketing away from me… and into that part of her mind, I always feared would take her away from me.

Aurora's RIPPED SAIL whips past in gale.

GILLY
I'm so sorry, Monroe.

Then stares off the edge of the crane.

MONROE
What do you think it's like to end a life?

GILLY
…Monroe?

MONROE
You must have thought about it too, right?
(shows his **bloody wrist**)
What if it's the only permanent thing here?

GILLY
Monroe, step back over here.

He doesn't move.

MONROE
Eighteen years, six months, and three hours. That's how long I've stood on that bridge waiting. That's how long I stared at a dingy, counted the feathers on a seagull's back, mapped every raindrop in this town…
(methodical)
…And calculated the exact thirty-three-foot drop that would plunge me deep enough beneath the gelatinous water to suffocate. <u>That's</u> how long I've waited and wondered and <u>*prayed*</u> for the rain to fall, for her to sail back over the horizon and talk me down. But I'm still here, trying to make a choice. Even though she already made hers.

GILLY
That choice… won't fix time.

MONROE
But how do you know?

GILLY
Because <u>that</u> choice… means no other choices.

MONROE
Yes. And no more Stillness.

The cyclone slows, sputtering like a dying engine. Monroes steps forward, balancing on ONE LEG.

GILLY
No, NO! You do NOT get to just leave me here.

He turns back.

MONROE
Then come with me.
(no response)
My mom never gave me a choice. But I will. Come with me.

GILLY
We--we can still fix time, go back--

MONROE
I will have no one to go back to.

GILLY
You have a father.

MONROE
So do you.
(beat)
Go home, Gilly.

GILLY
I can't.

MONROE
Then what's keeping you here?
(no answer)
No matter how many oceans you cross, you'll never outrun this. After all this time, how do you sit at the bus stop, and NOT want to join your mother -- slit your stomach open? End it all?

GILLY
Because that's what HE'd choose.
(beat)
So I choose NOT TO. And every time I wake up on that bench, I make that same fucking decision, over and over again.

He points to her hand, subconsciously placed on her belly.

MONROE
So why can't you make that one?

She can't answer. Monroe shakes his head in disbelief.

He bends his knees. Closes his eyes. Leans forward.

GILLY
Monroe. MONROE! MONROE!!! FINE.
JUST FUCKING DO IT.

He freezes.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Fuck what I care. Throw yourself over a ledge, snap your neck, bleed to death all over the lake. Death can't be much different than here, right? This world sucks and if we go back out there, that world sucks too. It's shit on top of shit of people pretending they're in control when no one has a clue. So don't learn to play guitar, never take another photo, never order another pancake, and fuck your career! Fuck your life! You'll never catch up. And if you do, it'll just be more impossible decisions where someone gets hurt because you made the wrong one.

She reaches into Monroe's bag and unravels the UNFINISHED PORTRAIT. She gathers FAST FOOD CONDIMENTS from the trash.

As she talks, she squeezes blobs of ketchup, mustard, and mayo into the air. Nudges them around as they float.

GILLY (CONT'D)
But if you step down and you try to live, if you step down and try to create something beautiful with your life -- fill it in with just the right shade of magenta or turquoise--

She releases the CANVAS. As it resets onto the windshield, it captures the paint. **It's Monroe's firefly technique.**

REVEAL THE FINISHED PORTRAIT -- Monroe's face resembles a smorgasbord of smeared colors and wiggly lines.

GILLY (CONT'D)
Then maybe you can make one, two, or seven wrong turns and know it's gonna be okay. Because someone still loves you. Because someone's still there… helping you find your way through the Stillness.

Monroe studies the FINISHED painting. It looks awful and is starting to fade. But for a moment… It's complete. He smiles at it a beat, then unravels--

MONROE
But if I move forward, she's gone. And if I stay in Stillness, she's also gone. I'm tired of photos that never move. I'm tired of paintings that always fade. And I'm tired of waiting. I'm SO SO tired of waiting and waiting and--

Suddenly, Gilly leaps forward and pulls Monroe from the edge.

They fold onto the platform. Monroe sobs. She holds him, rocking him, stroking his hair. Whispering--

GILLY
Shhhhh. You don't have to wait anymore, Monroe. Shhh…

Having run out of fuel, the Vortex begins to shrivel into a gently swirling spiral. Like leaves on the wind.

Monroe sobs in her arms. Finally letting the world slip away.

FADE TO BLACK.

EXT. LAKE, WAVE CREST - LATER

Struggling to stay awake, Monroe and Gilly hold each other on the wave to keep from floating away.

Around them, boats re-dock, trucks reverse, buildings reassemble, canals refill… The Vortex has run its course.

Time literally healing all wounds.

Gilly fiddles with the SILVER PAINTBRUSH, watching the last droplets of the pale-pink hues drain. Then suddenly--

GILLY
Gilly's not my real name.

Gilly takes out her embroidered BIBLE… hesitates --

GILLY (CONT'D)
It was my mom's… I-I lied to you. I'm sorry.

But exhausted, all Monroe can muster is…

MONROE
She must have been an amazing woman.

GILLY
My father met her in the garden, feeding the swans. Time just racing by. They'd go there every Sunday for years… until… me, I guess.
(smiles, then)
Is it possible to remember something that never happened to you?

MONROE
It's called a dream.

Gilly chuckles. Monroe struggles to stay awake.

GILLY
When you called me Gilly, it was like you made it real. Made her real. When you called me that, it was like I was home… Really home. I was… I just wanted to be Gilly all the time. Even to you.

He weaves his fingers through hers.

MONROE
You'll always be Gilly to me.

She smiles. Silence caresses them like a warm blanket.

Monroe's eyes fight to stay open. His arms begin to float up -- Gilly grabs them and holds him back down.

GILLY
Monroe, I've finally decided something--

MONROE
What's that?

GILLY
You are not a hallucination.

MONROE
Oh yeah? What finally gave it away?

GILLY
I could never imagine someone as kind and beautiful as you.

He smiles. Notices her gripping Aurora's paintbrush.

MONROE
Try. There are more people who love you than you could possibly imagine.
(re: paintbrush)
My mom would want you to keep that.

Emotions sweep over her. She nods.

The shadow of the resetting BRIDGE eclipses the sky. When it settles back in, sunlight sets the raindrops aglitter.

GILLY
I guess this wouldn't be the worst place to freeze.

MONROE
No, it wouldn't.

Monroe absorbs the way Gilly looks out at the water… her hand subconsciously on her belly.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Gilly, you have a tough decision to make. But it's YOUR decision. No one else's.
(poignant beat)
And I still think you should make one. Whenever you're ready.

GILLY
I've been here so long that if time starts again, I might just crumble into a pile of bones.

MONROE
Even so, I'll still be your friend. No matter what you decide to do with the baby. You're not alone.

GILLY
…Promise?

He takes Gilly's hand and brushes it against the PINK PAINT. He does the same with his and wraps his pinkie around hers.

MONROE
Pink promise.

Monroe closes his eyes, as we stay--

TIGHT ON GILLY, watching the lake. Something unlocking in her as the PINK fades and… ever-so-slowly a SNOWFLAKE crystalizes where a raindrop once was. Tiny and beautiful.

GILLY
Oh, Monroe… Look at that.

But Monroe's asleep. And Gilly's alone.

WIDEN TO REVEAL the snowflake is gone. But Gilly sees SOMETHING, mesmerized.

Careful not to stir him, she unwraps her scarf and coils it around his neck.

She leans in and WHISPERS SOMETHING to HIM. We don't hear it.

With a final kiss on the forehead, she releases Monroe and lets his sleeping body FLOAT AWAY. She rises and walks off, following what she just saw. We stay with Monroe as we--

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DREAM SEQUENCE

Right where we left off again, Monroe on the bridge, staring at that lone BALLOON from Aurora's bundle that never popped.

It floats off in the sluggish gravity. A dream-like distortion of time ***extends*** *the moment.*

Up ahead, Aurora's boat rockets toward the construction site.

EXT. MARINA - DAY

As Gilly walks, the raindrops **TURN TO SNOWFLAKES** behind her, as if she were a paintbrush herself, whiting out the world.

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DREAM SEQUENCE

Time has slowed to a crawl. ***EXCEPT FOR MONROE*** *everything inches forward at a decelerating pace. Globules of rain bleed from above. Like Stillness is closing in on reality.*

Monroe grips the rail on the bridge. Around him, CONCERNED ONLOOKERS exchange mumbles and glances.

MONROE
She'll be okay… she'll be back…

Monroe hesitates. Then opens his phone.

911 OPERATOR (ON PHONE)
(slow motion)
911 whaaaaat's your emergen--?

MONROE
My mom! She's not well, she's--

His fear fades suddenly. He observes his surroundings like a scientist. Becoming lucid in his fantastical dream.

Lethargic CARS eek forward in drunken slow-mo. The surf PUMMELS the bridge's beams. The clock strikes 10:16. A COAST GUARD jumps jet skis and chases after Aurora's boat.

The waves mushroom into castle-sized mounds. All in gentle, time-crunching ***slow motion.***

He lowers the phone and walks away. The ***WHITE GAP*** *crystallizes in his wake -- this moment being its genesis.*

INT. "KING'S GARDEN", ABANDONED PAVILION - DAY

CLOSE ON Gilly's face, captured in six feet of sterile stone.

Our Gilly stands tall in a field of pulverized snowflakes. She grips Monroe's baseball bat.

GILLY
I am not your legacy.

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DREAM SEQUENCE

LIGHTNING reaches across the sky in a long, lazy stretch.

Monroe watches Aurora's boat accelerate over a gorgeous wave--

Soaring. Weightless. Then--

INT. "KING'S GARDEN", COURTYARD - DAY

SLAM! Gilly swings at a construction plaque with his logo:

EXT. FINCHWOOD MONUMENT, CRASH SITE - DREAM SEQUENCE

The lone BALLOON floats above the crane.

Time has completely frozen in his dreams now.

Monroe pushes through a crowd of WORKERS and FIREMEN. The raindrops melt and reform with the same physics of Stillness.

Gravity suspends a steel girder at a perilous angle above the lake, freed in the aftermath of a powerful collision.

EXT. GRAVEYARD - DAY

Gilly dusts fresh snow off her MOTHER'S GRAVE. She wipes a tear but smiles.

She sees MONROE'S CAMERA, having washed ashore, it floats against a random gravestone. She chuckles and frees it.

EXT. AURORA'S SAILBOAT, CRASH SITE - DREAM SEQUENCE

Debris swirls all around in a magnificent COCOON, reminiscent of the Vortex. Monroe forges through the haze, striving to see the source at the storm's core, but can't find the way.

MONROE
Why did you do it, Mom? Why?

Something WHITE drifts down from the sky. Like snow. He reaches out and touches--

A WHITE FEATHER. Another one falls. Another. He looks up--

***A GIANT SWAN** peers down at Monroe.*

Enchanting and pure. It blinks and turns its head skyward--

As it does, we see its neck is INCOMPLETE. Just an impossible gap along the thin curve. Off Monroe's confusion--

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

Monroe stands on the bridge in his spot. *Frozen*… Like the others. For a long beat, we wait…

And just when you think he has succumbed to a frozen fate…

His eyes FLICK open, CRACKS from on the INVISIBLE FILM. It shatters like a pottery glaze.

In awe, he absorbs the shimmering SNOWFLAKES stretching over the lake. The town brims again with its bleak palette.

His hands fly to his neck to find Gilly's SCARF.

MONROE
Gilly? Hey Gilly!

Monroe unwraps the scarf and tosses it forward… But instead of guiding him, it whirls back around his neck.

Panic gathering, he starts running.

EXT. BUS STOP - DAY

Gilly traces her fingers through the frozen snowflakes as if through a pasture of silver wheat.

She sits on the bench, sinking into her **WHITE GAP** like a puzzle piece.

As she does, SNOW begins to lightly drift DOWN. So slowly, its movement feels like an optical illusion.

(CONTINUED)

She takes a deep breath… opens her phone.

GILLY
(into phone)
Dad?

EXT. CANALS - DAY

Racing through the snow, Monroe nearly rams into TOWNSFOLK in NEW SPOTS. With the new weather, they have shifted.

But he hardly processes, still desperately searching--

MONROE
GILLY! Don't do this to me, Gilly!

EXT. BUS STOP - DAY

As if she heard him, Gilly turns back a moment. Looking at SOMEONE. Smiles.

EXT. CANAL BRIDGE/STREETS - DAY

Still racing. He passes Nolan, now walking ABOVE the bridge.

MONROE
Don't do this-- don't…

SLAM TO:

INT. BUS STOP - DAY

Waves of sadness flood over him as he takes in the tableau.

MONROE
…Don't leave me.

The Pastor holds his daughter's hand at the bus stop. Determined, going somewhere. *Where*?

We're not sure, but they're going there together.

Tears speckle Gilly's cheeks, arched into a timid smile.

Frozen now. Lost to Monroe. Monroe's legs buckle.

INT. SILO - DAY

Bathed in the spectral light of his crank projector, Monroe curls up in his bean bag throne, his gaze hollow as he rewinds and watches his clip on a loop.

AURORA (O.S.)
Let's make a deal then. If you move forward in time, so will I.

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
Okay. Promise?

AURORA (O.S.)
Pink promise…

YOUNG MONROE (ON SCREEN)
A pink promise lasts forever, right?

Out of momentum, the crank stops -- the scene suspended right as the lens turned back to Grant.

MONROE
No, it doesn't! You can't stay in here -- in the Stillness… In these joyful, little moments--

With frantic hands, Monroe approaches his WALL OF POLAROIDS and begins ripping them down.

MONROE (CONT'D)
They all mean NOTHING. NOTHING. When everything's frozen. When that's all that's left of you--

Monroe CHUCKS the photos. They unfurl like a tornado.

MONROE (CONT'D)
IT ALL MEANS NOTHING!

He SHREDS it to ribbons. But as he grabs another, he freezes.

BECAUSE HIS POLAROIDS ARE MOVING

Like when you turn on the 'Live Moment' on an iPhone. The moments play out simultaneously in tiny, vivid **loops:**

- Fred finishes his race, arms cheering as he runs off.

- Nolan turns his pottery sign to "CLOSED" and goes home.

- Maxine and Natalie kiss in the rain and walk away together.

- Jason and Ellie embrace. Their boat drifts off with Hazel.

And maybe more we can't make out that Monroe must have taken earlier. They blur together in a dramatic mosaic. Fragments of time's incredible, yet terrifying linear wonder…

Gilly's kind voice whispers in his ear as he remembers--

GILLY (V.O.)
You don't have to understand it to make peace with it.

With the movement, HUSHED OVERLAPPING SOUNDS rush in like a waterfall -- *Fred's panting, the jingle of Nolan's keys, a soft parting of lips in a kiss, Hazel's innocent giggles.*

GILLY (V.O.)
The moment you do that... the world comes to life again.

Monroe's weight drags him to the floor as he watches--

One by one, his friends finish their stories and leave. Until just one photo remains: the selfie of him and Gilly.

In the once-frozen image, Gilly laughs, giving him bunny ears, and nudging him playfully. Then she exits the frame.

Leaving him the only frozen subject in a sea of change.

Monroe lifts his gaze to the projected image behind him, his silhouette enveloped within Grant's ghostly form.

INT./EXT. GRANT'S BUS - DAY

The bus has traveled further down the lake, closer to town. Monroe wanders inside shyly, searching the NEW PASSENGERS--

MONROE
Grant?

But his seat is empty. Disappointed, Monroe sits instead.

Reflective, he looks out the window… noticing SOMEONE.

EXT. COMMUNITY CENTER, GALLERY - MOMENTS LATER

Monroe steps off the bus and crosses the street to the gallery entrance. A grateful grin curls across his cheeks.

MONROE
You made it.

GRANT hovers just outside the entrance, as if working himself up to push through those doors. His briefcase has opened to unveil a GIFT, which he clutches with uncertainty.

Monroe approaches, slipping out the gift--

A BABY BOOK adorned with a bow. The front page captures Monroe deeply engrossed in his camera lens.

As he flips through the album, each image has a CAPTION. Formatted like a CHILDREN'S STORYBOOK.

GRANT (V.O.)
Once upon a timeless Kingdom, an unfinished boy searched for his mom among an everlasting Stillness.

On the first page, a photo of the CHURCH.

INT. COMMUNITY CENTER, GALLERY - DAY

Monroe opens a janitor's closet, releasing his oversized suit. It floats over and cloaks him.

GRANT (V.O.)
But instead stumbled upon a troubled Queen and her fabled King.

EXT. CANALS - DAY

Monroe high-fives Fred, his arms raised in mid-cheer.

He then waves goodbye to Nolan; the man jingles his house keys as he finally walks home along the canals.

GRANT (V.O.)
Young, arrogant, and amazingly wealthy, of all his creations, King believed his greatest was himself.

He looks up at a KING LOGO in the courtyard.

EXT. "KING'S GARDEN", COURTYARD - DAY

Monroe's gaze lingers on the empty pedestal beside King's, where Gilly's statue would have stood.

GRANT (V.O.)
He vowed to build a legacy that would last forever…

EXT. THE BIRDHOUSE DINER - DAY

Monroe nibbles pancakes, slurping beer from a jar as he flips through the baby book, landing on--

GRANT (V.O.)
So when he saw his chance for one…

--an **ULTRASOUND.** His brow arcs in awe. Then twists in horror.

GRANT (V.O.)
For the first time, he was in love.

With trembling hands, Monroe slides out an ENVELOPE addressed to him, flipping through years of HANDWRITTEN LETTERS. Even a BLANK CHECK. All scribbled on **KING CO. STATIONARY.**

In the window, the CONSTRUCTION SITE looms like a dark omen.

EXT. MARINA - DAY

Monroe joins Ellie and Jason's embrace on their boat.

In the book, a WEDDING PHOTO of Aurora (face under a veil) and Grant. Besides them, **BABY MONROE** sleeps in a blue basket.

GRANT (V.O.)
Time rolled on and one day the Queen met a Giant with a timid but trustworthy heart.

EXT. MONROE'S HOUSE, STUDY - DAY

We drift past Grant's models, shrouded in cobwebs and patina.

GRANT (V.O.)
The Giant poured his heart into every battle against relentless foes.

At the desk, Monroe flips through Grant's REJECTED PROPOSALS for the construction site address over the years:

A theater, an art museum, a school… the clinic. All rejected.

GRANT (V.O.)
Yet emerged victorious in the battle that mattered most of all.

Finally, the only doc APPROVED -- **PETITION FOR STEP-PARENT ADOPTION.** With a small asterisk.*

A judge has approved it, ***PENDING MONROE'S DECISION.***

A soft smile as he runs his fingers along Grant's signature.

An empty line awaits his own.

INT. COMMUNITY CENTER, GALLERY - DAY

With pride, Monroe hangs his CHOSEN PHOTO on his gallery wall -- Grant in his yellow vest, sitting at the bus stop.

GRANT (V.O.)
Cause fighting for what you love,
is never a waste of time.

WIDEN TO REVEAL, more photos of Grant at the bus stop every day. Almost the same photo over and over. The time-lapse.

EXT. COASTAL OUTLOOK - DAY

Monroe ducks beside Natalie and Maxine's umbrella. Smiles at the two girls kissing. He waves goodbye.

GRANT (V.O.)
Never a waste of hope…

EXT. MONROE'S HOUSE, FOYER - DAY

We glide past Aurora's museum of UNFINISHED CREATURES.

GRANT (V.O.)
As the years went by, the Queen
spent nights trying to rebuild
Stillness, painting the creatures
of her Kingdom.

CLOSE ON, the jagged edges of a **WHITE GAP** sawing through a brush stroke like sharks' teeth. Resembling King's logo.

GRANT (V.O.)
But she always ran out of time
before she finished.

EXT. LAKEFRONT DOCK - DAY

In Aurora's tote, Monroe digs past the EMPTY PILL BOTTLE, finding her phone -- the screen has frozen on cryptic TEXT:

Unknown Number: YOU CANNOT IGNORE ME FOREVER.

A press flyer is attached for the **FINCHWOOD MONUMENT RE-GROUNDBREAKING CEREMONY.** Celebrating King's grand return.

GRANT (V.O.)
All her life, the Queen couldn't
finish a single painting.

Jutting out from a rusty nail is the STRIP of CLOTH Monroe tore from the sail in his dream… but a closer look reveals--

It's Aurora's suicide note, written on a strip of CANVAS.

GRANT (V.O.)
Then one night, she went to sleep and couldn't finish her own dream.

A bittersweet smile as Monroe reads her final words to him -- *"No more running."*

EXT. FINCHWOOD BRIDGE - DAY

Monroe walks a shimmering path through the suspended snowflakes, approaching the **WHITE GAP** on the bridge.

His camera hangs around an invisible neck, having reset.

GRANT (V.O.)
She's been trapped inside it ever since.

He threads his head through the loop. Then centers himself. As he sits, the **WHITE GAP** heals around him.

When he rises, the gap is no more. The canvas is complete.

EXT. FINCHWOOD MONUMENT, STAGE - DAY

Red and blue emergency lights bounce wicked shadows off a sign for 'FINCHWOOD MONUMENT GROUND RE-BREAKING!' The air crackles with the hiss of an electrical fire.

Monroe ducks under the CAUTION TAPE, passing ONLOOKERS, looking up at this miraculous snow and the chaos.

FIREMEN attempt to dislodge the FALLEN CRANE from the grotesque ruins of AURORA'S BOAT, which has launched itself off the lake and through the STAGE, kamikaze style.

The TURPENTINE flames churn a sickly blue-grey hue.

Monroe's chest heaves. He stops, overtaken by emotion. Then OPENS his dad's album to the final page--

GRANT (V.O.)
Finish her dream or begin anew, the next chapter belongs to you.

A BLANK PAGE for a new photo/caption.

MONROE
Thanks, Dad.

Monroe claws over wood scraps, passing King's WHITE PONTIAC parked nearby. He boards the boat crashing through the stage--

EXT. AURORA'S SAILBOAT, CRASH SITE - CONTINUOUS

Monroe navigates onto the sloping deck, ravaged and crumpled within a megaton of maternal force.

He brushes aside the broken mast to reveal her boat's target: **A STATUE OF YOUNG MONROE.** Akin to Gilly's. A lopsided banner hangs above the stage, announcing KING CO'S NEW LOGO:

KING & SON CONSTRUCTION COMPANY

Two Crowns now -- a big one overlapping a smaller one. King's attempt to win Monroe over as father.

MONROE
I am not your legacy.

A CANVAS lies overturned on the deck, a gaping TEAR it from the strip Aurora ripped to write her suicide note.

Monroe approaches and flips over the painting to reveal--

A SWAN. Enchanting and pure. With an INCOMPLETE NECK.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I think I know why you left them unfinished.

Monroe traces the GAP between the Swan's neck and body.

MONROE (CONT'D)
The white edges -- they're a part of it. Of us. And they're just as beautiful. Because they let us keep growing, make new decisions… Like the one you must've made.
(smiles knowingly)
Because I'm here.

He reaches into Aurora's pocket, and pries out--

MONROE (CONT'D)
And even if you'd chosen differently, it would have been okay.

--GILLY'S PIN. Faded with time.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I promise, Gilly.

And for the first time, we see Aurora's face.

GILLY has grown into the passionate, playful voice that guided Monroe all along, on his journey through Stillness.

(CONTINUED)

In her final moments, slumped over the wheel, a metal beam PIERCES her chest.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Because this world, this time. It's all jumbled up. That's how we found each other, and how we'd find each other again and again. In some temporal pitstop in between, going through the same shit, just in different directions…

His voice breaks.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Which is why I have to break our promise, Mom.

With shaky hands, he slots the torn canvas strip into the swan's missing neck, fumbling to match the ragged edges.

MONROE (CONT'D)
I have to move forward without you.
(gaining confidence)
Even if I fuck up, it's okay… Cause I've got time.
(touches his camera)
Cause I've got a whole world to capture. And I can't do it stuck inside one small frame.
(beat)
Cause my story's just beginning…

He steps back, admiring the COMPLETED SWAN. Then turns to her.

MONROE (CONT'D)
Even if yours is finished…

He wraps his pinkie around hers, taking in his mother's final moments -- eyes closed in a restful slumber. And even a slight smile as she finally finds her own sort of Stillness.

His body shakes. Snot spews. Ugly and visceral.

MONROE (CONT'D)
So I guess what I'm saying is… I guess… I just want you to know… I'm ready. I'm ready. I'm--

Emotions overwhelm him. He careens forward.

But right as he is about to hit the deck--

RAM!

GRANT'S arms grapple around his son.

GRANT
It's okay. It's gonna be okay.

And Monroe knows this must be true… as a SWAN near shore drifts by, a BABY on her back.

Grant just holds him, rocking back and forth as Monroe sobs into his father's embrace.

The boat tilts as the firemen invade the private scene.

And WE WIDEN OUT to reveal the tranquil snow falling.

TITTER-TATTER. TITTER-TATTER.

A quiet lullaby. Yet earth-shattering… All powerful…

As time thunders forward.

FADE TO WHITE.

THE END